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Mystery and Secrecy

in the Nag Hammadi Collection

and Other Ancient Literature:

Ideas and Practices

Nag Hammadi and

Manichaean Studies

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Johannes van Oort & Einar Thomassen
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Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient Literature: Ideas and Practices

Studies for Einar Thomassen at Sixty

Edited by

Christian H. Bull, Liv Ingeborg Lied and John D. Turner

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FOREWORD

This book is offered in honor of Einar Thomassen on the occasion of his 60th birthday. The collection of essays

in this Festschrift explores what Walter Burkert once described as “the fascination of secrecy and the promise of thrilling revelations”:1 mystery and secrecy in the Nag Hammadi texts and other ancient texts and practices. This multivalent and fascinating topic is fijitting for a celebration of Thomassen’s broad scholarly production and wide research interests in the religious currents of Antiquity.

In scholarly discourse the term “mystery” (deriving, via Latin, from the Greek word μυστήριον) usually refers to a secret rite, and/or to exclusive and treasured knowledge in the form of a revealed secret. The mystery often reveals cosmological or ontological truths. It may be the disclo-
sure of God’s general plan, of hidden heavenly realities, unknown earthly truths, the real layout of past events, or a description of things to come. The mystery is commonly revealed by God or other divine agents, and is

conveyed to the worthy recipients through revelatory dialogues, visions, rites or other practices. It is often of limited public exposure, and provides those who have gained access to it knowledge of things at and beyond the limits of knowability. The precise contents of ancient mystery rites often remain unknown (and hence the more intriguing). However, the functions and uses of references to mystery and mystery language in ancient texts are generally available for study. These texts show that references to mystery and use of mystery language may serve epistemological, cognitive, and social purposes: it informs pedagogical, rhetorical, and soteriological discourses: and may also be used as a way of establishing authority. In yet other ancient texts, mystery can also be used for an opposite purpose, as a means of shaming certain ungodly, dangerous, hidden and inaccessible rites and practices of “the religious other.”

The term “secrecy” refers to a strategy of distribution of control over, and access to special knowledge: the valued information generally reserved for the few. Secrecy can be understood as a social phenomenon, as discourse within a real or imagined society, as well as a rhetorical strategy. Secrecy

1 Walter Burkert, Ancient Mystery Cults (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1987), 1.

tends to promote exclusivity, since access to the secret provides those who know it with social, epistemological and soteriological advantages.

The topic of mystery and secrecy is a broad, complex and intriguing one. As suggested above, it refers both to a set of ritual practices, as well as to a multivalent literary theme and metaphorical language in narrative texts of the ancient Mediterranean and Middle East. The topic is found across geographical, cultural and

religious borders, as well as in written sources of difffering genres and languages. Moreover, these sources display
multiple functions, and diverse contexts of usage. In this sense, the topic of mystery and secrecy reflects Thomassen's academic profijile perfectly.

Thomassen's research on Valentinianism, the Nag Hammadi texts and
early Christian pluralism are well known. However, he has also taken great interest in other religious strands in antique Mediterranean and Middle Eastern societies, including a variety of Greek, Roman and Near Eastern religious and philosophical traditions, and has paired this interest with an important insight into theoretical and methodological currents in Religious Studies. The theme of mystery and secrecy traces a thread through a major part of Thomassen's scholarship. His research portfo-
lio displays a profound interest in the relationship between text, myth

and ritual; the functions of revelation, knowledge, secrecy and pedagogy; notions of cosmology, dualism, protology and eschatology; not to men-
tion identity construction and social settings of ancient religions and their texts. Thomassen has contributed specifijically to the scholarly discussion
of mystery and secrecy on several occasions, for instance in his seminal work The Spiritual Seed: The Church of the “Valentinians” (2006), as well as in the essays “Revelation as Book and Book as Revelation: Reflections of the Gospel of Truth” (2002), and “Gos. Philip 67:27–30: Not ‘in a mystery’” (2006).2 He has stressed, among other aspects, the soteriological impor-
tance of the special knowledge of revealed books and the social value of secret wisdom in the community of the elect. Importantly, Thomassen has

2 E.g., Einar Thomassen, The Spiritual Seed: The Church of the ‘Valentinians’ (NHMS 60;

Leiden: Brill, 2006); idem, “Revelation as Book and Book as Revelation: Reflections on the Gospel of Truth,” in The Nag Hammadi Texts in the History of Religions: Proceedings of the International Conference at the Royal Academy of Sciences and Letters in Copenhagen, September 19–24, 1995: On The Occasion of the 50th Anniversary of the Nag Hammadi Discovery (ed. Søren Giversen, Tage Petersen and Jørgen Podemann Sørensen; Historisk-fijilosofijiske Skrifter 26; Copenhagen: The Royal Danish Academy of Sciences and Letters, 2002), 35–45; idem, “Gos. Philip 67:27–30: Not ‘in a mystery,’ ” in Coptica-Gnostica-Manichaica: Mélanges offferts à Wolf-Peter Funk (ed. Louis Painchaud & Paul-Hubert Poirier; BCNH.E 7; Québec: Les Presses de l’Université Laval/Louvain: Éditions Peeters, 2006), 925–39.

explored and proposed an alternative reading of the oft-cited reference to “mystery”—the “symbolic meaning”—of the acts of the Savior in the Gospel of Philip 67.

The contributions to this Festschrift discuss references to mystery and secrecy in a variety of ancient sources. We have invited Thomassen’s international colleagues as well as his former students at the University of Bergen to contribute essays in their respective fijields of expertise. These range from the Eleusinian Mysteries in ancient Greece to mystery and authority building in the writings of Shenoute of Atripe. The fijirst part of this volume focuses on Nag Hammadi and Gnostic writings. The second part addresses other Christian practices, text traditions and material cul-
ture. Finally, the third part discusses non-Christian trends of Antiquity. Hence, the volume offfers an up to date

presentation of research on the currents of mystery and secrecy in the ancient world. These include a close look at the Nag Hammadi texts; other early Christian and Jewish texts; Manichean, Mithraic, and Hermetic traditions; as well as mystery rites and other mystic practices and rituals.

The editors wish to thank, in particular, Johannes van Oort. This volume is published in the Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies Series, of which Thomassen is one of the series editors. Ironically, this volume on mystery and secrecy has itself been a well kept secret for some years, not the least due to the effforts of van Oort, the other series editor. Thanks are
also due to Jan Bremmer who suggested the topic for the anthology, to Hilde Marie Ø. Movafagh for compiling the indices, to Hugo Lundhaug for assisting the editors with his expertise on fonts, to MF Norwegian

School of Theology for economic support, to Mattie Kuiper and the stafff of Brill for bringing the volume to completion, to Thomassen's colleagues in Bergen and the SBL Nag Hammadi and Gnosticism Session for offfering the venue for the presentation of the book.

Finally, our thanks go to Einar. Through his books and articles, and his engagement in the raising of new generations of scholars in the Nordic Nag Hammadi and Gnosticism Network, Einar's legacy continues to influence scholarship. For this we are particularly thankful.

The editors

ABBREVIATIONS

AAAH Acta ad archaeologiam et artium historiam pertinentia
ABD The Anchor Bible Dictionary
ABRL The Anchor Bible Reference Library
AGSJU Arbeiten zur Geschichte des antiken Judentums und des

Urchristentums

AJA American Journal of Archaeology

AJN 2 American Journal of Numismatics, Second Series

ANET Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament. Edited by James B. Pritchard. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1993

ANF The Ante-Nicene Fathers. Edited by Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson. 1885–1887. 10 vols. Repr. Grand Rapids, Eerdmans, 1986

ANRW Aufstieg und Niedergang der römischen Welt. Geschichte und Kultur Roms im Spiegel der neueren Forschung. Part 2, Principat. Edited by Hildegard Temporini and Wolfgang Haase. New York: Walter de Gruyter, 1974–1998

AnzSchweiz Anzeiger für schweizerische Alterthumskunde

AOAT Alter Orient und Altes Testament

AR Archiv für Religionswissenschaft

Athen. Mitt. Athenische Mitteilungen
AVM Archeologie in Vlaanderen
Monografijie
BBB Bonner biblische Beiträge
BCH Bulletin de correspondance
hellénique
BCNH.É Bibliothèque copte de Nag
Hammadi, section “Études”
BCNH.T Bibliothèque copte de Nag
Hammadi, section “Textes”
BibInt Biblical Interpretation
BIS Biblical Interpretation Series
BJS The British Journal of Sociology
BP Bibliothèque de la Pléiade
BS Bollingen Series
BSGRT Bibliotheca scriptorum graecorum
et romanorum teub neriana
BTB Biblical Theology Bulletin
BZNW Beihefte zur Zeitschrift für die
neutestamentliche

Wissen schaft

CBQ Catholic Biblical Quarterly
CBR Currents in Biblical Research
CChr Corpus christianorum
CdE Chronique d’Égypte

CGL The Coptic Gnostic Library
CMCL Corpus dei manoscritti copti letterari
ConBNT Coniectanea biblica: New Testament Series
COr Cahiers d'orientalisme
CQ Classical Quarterly
CRINT Compendia rerum iudaicarum ad Novum Testamentum
CTSRR College Theology Society Resources in Religion
DDD Dictionary of Deities and Demons in the Bible
DMAHA Dutch Monographs on Ancient History and Archaeology
DTC Dictionnaire de théologie catholique
EBib Études bibliques
EJMS Electronic Journal of Mithraic Studies
EPRO Etudes préliminaires aux religions orientales dans l'empire romain
FRLANT Forschungen zur Religion und Literatur des Alten und Neuen Testaments
GCS Die griechischen-christlichen

Schriftsteller der ersten drei

Jahrhunderte

GRBS Greek, Roman, and Byzantine Studies

HDR Harvard Dissertations in Religion

HNT Handbuch zum Neuen Testament

HSCP Harvard Studies in Classical

Philology

HSem Horae semiticae

HTR Harvard Theological Review

HTS Harvard Theological Studies

JAC Jarbuch für Antike und Christentum

JBL Journal of Biblical Literature

JCTCRS Jewish and Christian Texts in

Context and Related Studies

JdI Jahrbuch des Deutschen

Archäologischen Instituts

JEA The Journal of Egyptian Archaeology

JECS Journal for Early Christian Studies

JRS Journal of Roman Studies

JSJ Journal for the Study of Judaism in

the Persian, Hellenistic, and

Roman Period

JSJSup Supplements to the Journal for

the Study of Judaism

JSNTSup Journal for the Study of the New Testament: Supplement Series

JSPSup Journal for the Study of the Pseudepigrapha: Supplement Series

JSRC Jerusalem Studies in Religion and Culture

JTS Journal of Theological Studies

LCL The Loeb Classical Library

LHBOTS Library of Hebrew Bible/ Old Testament Studies

LIMC Lexicon iconographicum mythologiae classicae. Edited by Hans C. Ackermann and Jean-Robert Gisler. 8 vols. Zürich: Artemis Verlag, 1981–1997

LSTS Library of Second Temple Studies

MHSMB Manichäische Handschriften der staatlichen Museen Berlin

Mus Muséon: Revue d’études orientales

NCBC The New Cambridge Bible Commentary

NGWG Nachrichten von der königlichen Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen, Philologische-historische Klasse

NHMS Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies

NHS Nag Hammadi Studies
NovTSup Supplements to Novum Testamentum
NTS New Testament Studies
NTTS New Testament Tools and Studies
OCA Orientalia christiana analecta
OCD The Oxford Classical Dictionary
OCT Scriptorum classicorum bibliotheca oxoniensis (Oxford Classical Texts)
OECT Oxford Early Christian Studies
OLA Orientalia lovaniensia analecta
OLP Orientalia lovaniensia periodica
PapyCol Papyrologica coloniensia
ParOr Parole de l'orient
PFTUG Publications de la Faculté de théologie de l'Université de Genève
PNIA Papers from the Norwegian Institute at Athens
PS Patristic Studies
PTR Princeton Theological Review
PTS Patristische Texte und Studien
RAC Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum. Edited by Theodor Kluser, Franz J. Dölger, and Ernst Dassmann. Stuttgart:

Hierse mann, 1950–

REG Revue des études grecques
RGRW Religions in the Graeco-Roman World
RHR Revue de l’histoire des religions
RSLR Rivista di storia e letteratura religiosa
RSMS Ritual Studies Monograph Series
RSR Revue des sciences religieuses
RVV Religionsgeschichtliche Versuche und Vorarbeiten

SAC Studies in Antiquity and Christianity
SAOC Studies in Ancient Oriental Civilization
SBLDS Society of Biblical Literature Dissertation Series
SBLMS Society of Biblical Literature Monograph Series
SBLSP Society of Biblical Literature Seminar Papers
SBLTT Society of Biblical Literature Texts and Translations
SC Sources chrétiennes
SCHNT Studia ad corpus hellenisticum Novi Testamenti

SECA Studies on Early Christian Apocrypha

SGRR Studies in Greek and Roman Religion

SHR Studies in the History of Religions. Numen Book Series

SMSR Studi e materiali di storia delle religioni

SR Studies in Religion

STAC Studien und Texte zu Antike und Christentum

STDJ Studies on the Texts of the Desert of Judah

StOR Studies in Oriental Religions

SWE Studies in Western Esotericism

TDNT Theological Dictionary of the New Testament. Edited by Gerhard Kittel and Gerhard Friedrich. Translated by Geofffrey W. Bromiley. 10 vols. Grand Rapids, Eerdmans, 1964–1976

ThesCRA Thesaurus cultuum et rituum antiquorum

TSAJ Texte und Studien zum antiken Judentum

TTS Thomas Taylor Series

TU Texte und Untersuchungen

VC Vigiliae christianae
VCSup Supplements to Vigiliae christianae
VetChr Vetera christianorum
VT Vetus testamentum
WGRW Writings from the Graeco-Roman World
WUNT Wissenschaftliche Untersuchungen zum Neuen Testament
ZÄS Zeitschrift für ägyptische Sprache und Altertumskunde
ZAW Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft

ZNW Zeitschrift für die neutestamentliche Wissenschaft und die Kunde der älteren Kirche
ZPE Zeitschrift für Papyrologie und Epigraphik
ZRGG Zeitschrift für Religions- und Geistesgeschichte

LIST OF CONTRIBUTORS

Jonas Bjørnebye is Post-doctoral Fellow and holder of the Stein Erik

Hagen-chair at The Norwegian Institute in Rome.

David Brakke is Professor of Religious Studies at Indiana University.

Jan N. Bremmer is Emeritus Professor of Religious Studies at the University of Groningen.

Christian H. Bull is PhD-student of History of Religions at the University of Bergen.

April D. DeConick is Isla Carroll and Percy E. Turner Professor of Biblical Studies at Rice University.

Jean-Daniel Dubois is Directeur d'études of Sciences religieuses at the École pratique des hautes etudes in Paris.

Ismo Dunderberg is Professor of New Testament Studies at the University of Helsinki.

Karen L. King is Hollis Professor of Divinity at Harvard University.

Dimitris J. Kyrtatas is Professor of the History of Late Antiquity at the University of Thessaly.

Liv Ingeborg Lied is Associate Professor of Religious Studies at MF Norwegian School of Theology in Oslo.

Hugo Lundhaug is Associate Professor of Patristics and Religious Studies at MF Norwegian School of Theology in Oslo.

Antti Marjanen is Professor of Gnosticism and Early Christian Literature at the University of Helsinki.

Marvin Meyer is Griset Professor of Christian Studies and Director of the Albert Schweitzer Institute, Chapman University.

Louis Painchaud is Professeur titulaire at the Faculté de théologie et de sciences religieuses

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The Platonizing Sethian Background of
Plotinus's Mysticism

The Platonizing Sethian Background of
Plotinus’s Mysticism

Nag Hammadi and
Manichaean Studies

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By

Alexander J. Mazur

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For Sasha

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Editor's Preface to the Present Volume

The present monograph is a revision of Dr. Alexander J. 'Zeke' Mazur's 2010 doctoral dissertation (submitted to the Committee on the History of Culture, University of Chicago, August 2010), a pioneering work in the study of Plotinus and his relationship with Gnosticism, particularly with reference to the Coptic Gnostic works discovered near Nag Hammadi, Egypt, ca. December 1945. Many scholars, including myself, obtained copies of the long-awaited dissertation as soon as they were available and were impressed by its depth and originality. In 2011, Dr. Mazur submitted the dissertation to Nag Hammadi and

Manichaean
Studies for publication, and the series' managing editor at the time for Nag Hammadi, Prof. Einar Thomassen, accepted it on a provisional basis. This was welcome news, as anyone who had read the dissertation understood that it is a truly significant contribution to the study of Plotinus as well as the philosophi-
cal import of the Nag Hammadi Codices.

Following his tragic, unexpected death in August 2016, Dr. Mazur's notes and work-in-progress were given to his mentor and collaborator Prof. Jean-Marc Narbonne. Together with Prof. Narbonne, Prof. John D. Turner (†2019) went about the task of sorting through Dr. Mazur's (digital) Nachlass so as to determine what might be brought to publication. Thanks to the efforts of Prof.
Narbonne as well as Dr. Francis Lacroix, a set of Dr. Mazur's studies focused principally on Plotinus's treatise Against the Gnostics (Ennead II.9[33])

has al-
ready been published in English,1 with
an abridged version in French to fol-
low in the Collection Budé. Meanwhile,
at the June 2017 conference of the
International Society of Neoplatonic
Studies in Olomouc, Czech Republic,
Prof. Turner and I agreed that Mazur's
dissertation was already sufficiently
developed to be published without
significant editing of content, that
Mazur
himself would have wanted to see its
publication (given proper editorial
care),
and that we should undertake editorial
work on its style and formatting.

It was not difficult to organize a
circle of Dr. Mazur's friends and
colleagues
who agreed to share the assignment. Over
the course of 2018–2020, Prof. Kevin
Corrigan, Dr. Ivan Miroshnikov, Dr.
Tuomas Rasimus, and Prof. Turner very
generously contributed their time,
expertise, and effort in editing this

book
for style and formatting. I shared in
their labors and coordinated the team,

1 Zeke Mazur, Introduction and
Commentary to Plotinus's Treatise 33
(II.9) 'Against the Gnostics'
and Related Studies, edited by Francis
Lacroix and Jean-Marc Narbonne (Zetesis;
Laval:
Presses de l'Université Laval, 2019).

with the invaluable support of my
assistants at the Freie Universität
Berlin,
Elisabeth Koch, Janik Petersdorff, and
Philipp Scharfenberger. It is thanks to
these individuals that Dr. Mazur's
brilliant dissertation has enjoyed a
worthy
κόσμησις and finally been made available
to the scholarly community beyond
those who had access to the original
Chicago dissertation, in a state that
should
invite the engagement of scholars of

Neoplatonism, Nag Hammadi studies, and related fields.

Prof. Turner and I agreed from the start that the best way to respect Dr. Mazur's work was to change as little of the Chicago dissertation as possible—to clean up what was already there, permitting the treasures this silenos already conceals to shine all the more. Thus, we have not significantly edited Mazur's arguments or interpretations of evidence, nor his prose. Nor have we added reference to any of the significant secondary literature on Plotinus and the Gnostics which has appeared in the last decade.2 Rather, the team, to the best of its ability, corrected typos and references, controlled the Greek and Coptic text, removed the occasional spurious reference (never with significant effect on Dr. Mazur's argument), and standardized references, formatting, and bibliography. Details

regarding references and translations are found on the following pages.

The relationship between Gnosticism and later Platonism, and in particular the thought of Plotinus and Porphyry, is one of the most exciting and promising trajectories of research today for scholars of later Greek philosophy, ancient Christianity, and Coptology alike. With the passing of Dr. Mazur in 2016 and Prof. Turner in 2019, the investigation of this trajectory has lost two of its

2 Monographs include Jean-Marc Narbonne, Plotinus in Dialogue with the Gnostics (Studies in Platonism, Neoplatonism, and the Platonic Tradition 11; Leiden; Boston: Brill, 2011); Nicola Spanu, Plotinus, ‘Ennead’ II 9 [33] ‘Against the Gnostics’: A Commentary (Studia Patristica Supplement 1; Leuven: Peeters, 2012); Dylan M. Burns, Apocalypse of the Alien God: Platonism and the Exile of Sethian Gnosticism

(Divinations; Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2014); Sebastian Gertz, Plotinus. Ennead II.9: Against the Gnostics: Translation, with an Introduction and Commentary (The Enneads of Plotinus; Las Vegas; Zürich; Athens: Parmenides Press, 2017); Nicholas Banner, Philosophic Silence and the 'One' in Plotinus (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2018). Volumes of papers with relevant studies include but are not limited to Kevin Corrigan and Tuomas Rasimus, with Dylan M. Burns, Lance Jenott, and Zeke Mazur (eds.), Gnosticism, Platonism, and the Late Ancient World: Essays in Honour of John D. Turner (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies 82; Leiden: Brill, 2013); Gnosis: Journal of Gnostic Studies 1–2 (2016); Helmut Seng and Giulia Sfamena Gasparro (eds.), Theologische Orakel in der

Spätantike (Bibliotheca Chaldaica 5; Universitätsverlag
Winter: Heidelberg, 2016); Helmut Seng, Luciana Soares Santoprete, and Chiara O. Tommasi
Moreschini (eds.), Formen und Nebenformen des Platonismus in der Spätantike (Bibliotheca
Chaldaica 6; Universitätsverlag Winter: Heidelberg, 2016); Chiara O. Tommasi, Luciana Soares
Santoprete, and Helmut Seng (eds.), Hierarchie und Ritual: Zur philosophischen Spiritualität
in der Spätantike (Bibliotheca Chaldaica 7; Universitätsverlag Winter: Heidelberg, 2018).

greatest minds and advocates. It is the hope of the ‘friends of Zeke’ who edited the present volume that its publication will stimulate others to reflect further on Plotinus, his mysterious friends, and the significance of the Nag Hammadi texts for our understanding of religion

and philosophy in late antiquity and beyond.

Dylan Michael Burns
Berlin-Charlottenburg, 5 May 2020

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Zeke Mazur
Cambridge, MA, 2010

Editor’s Note on References, Editions, and Translations

The style guide used by the editorial team for this volume was the SBL Handbook of Style (2014), although some of Dr. Mazur’s preferences remain unchanged: for instance, primary sources are almost never abbreviated, but given with full Latin title. A list of the abbreviations that are used throughout
are found below.

Only those primary sources which are quoted in the text are listed in the bibliography. Primary sources are listed in the bibliography by modern editor or translator, with the exception of Plotinus himself (under “Plotinus”). Greek
sources appear to have been translated by Dr. Mazur, presumably with reference to available translations.

Dr. Mazur’s treatment of the text of Plotinus merits special mention. He quoted the Greek text of Plotinus according to the editio maior of Henry

and
Schwyzer (H-S1), while adapting the translations of Armstrong in the Loeb Classical Library. However, Armstrong's Greek text is based upon the editio minor (H-S2), not the editio maior (H-S1), and includes other emendations not found in H-S1. In cases where the text of Armstrong does not agree with that of H-S1, Dr. Mazur has usually (but not always) opted for Armstrong.
Accordingly,
where the two editions differ, the team has indicated the discrepancy by putting the reading rejected by Mazur in brackets. Thus, "τῇ αἰσθήσει [H-S1: διαθέσει]"
(at VI.9[9].7.17–21) means that here, Armstrong's text does not agree with H-S1,
and Mazur has preferred Armstrong's αἰσθήσει to H-S1's διαθέσει. Conversely,
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The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a
Teacher of
Hellenized Wisdom

By

Christian H. Bull

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Orphée
Admirez le pouvoir insigne
Et la noblesse de la ligne:
Elle est la voix que la lumière fit
entendre
Et dont parle Hermès Trismégiste en son
Pimandre.

Ibis
Oui, j’irai dans l’ombre terreuse
O mort certaine, ainsi soit-il!
Latin mortel, parole affreuse.
Ibis, oiseau des bords du Nil.

Guillaume Apollinaire, Le Bestiaire ou Cortège d’Orphée (1911)

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After defending my dissertation, I worked as a post-doctoral researcher between 2014 and 2016 for the project "New Contexts for Old Texts: Unorthodox Texts and Monastic Manuscript Culture in Fourth- and Fifth-Century Egypt" (NEWCONT), based at the Faculty of Theology, University of Oslo.1 I am most

1 The project was funded by the European Research Council (ERC) under the European Community's Seventh Framework Programme (FP7/2007–2013) / ERC Grant Agreement no. 283741.

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2 FRIPRO mobility grant, project 250781. Jointly funded by the Norwegian Research Council
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Abbreviations

Commonly Cited Works

Ascl.
CCAG

CH

DH

FH

FR

HHE

KK

NF

PD

PGM

PGMT

Scott

SH

The Asclepius, the Latin translation of PD

Franz Cumont and Franz Boll, eds., Catalogus Codicum Astrologorum Graecorum. 12 vols. Brussels: Lamertin, 1898–1953

Corpus Hermeticum, in NF vols. 1–2

Definitions of Hermes Trismegistus to Asclepius. In HHE vol. 2

Fragmenta Hermetica, in NF vol. 4

André-Jean Festugière, La révélation d’Hermès Trismégiste. 4 vols. Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1944–1954

Jean-Pierre Mahé, Hermès en haute-Égypte. 2 vols. BCNH.C 3 & 7. Québec: Les Presses de l'Université Laval, 1978–1982
The Korê Kosmou = SH XXIII
Arthur D. Nock and André-Jean Festugière. Hermès Trismégiste: Corpus Hermeticum. 4 vols. Paris, 1942–1953
The Perfect Discourse
Karl Preisendanz, Papyri graecae magicae. Die griechischen Zauberpapyri. 3 vols. Stuttgart: Teubner, 1928–1973
Hans D. Betz (ed.), The Greek Magical Papyri in Translation. Including the Demotic spells. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986
Walter Scott, Hermetica: the ancient Greek and Latin writings which contain religious or philosophic teachings ascribed to Hermes Trismegistus. Oxford: Clarendon, 1924–1936
Stobaei Hermetica, in NF vols. 2–3

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Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament. Edited by J.B. Pritchard. 3d ed. Princeton, 1969

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CP

CRBL

EAC

EQÄ

EPRO

EVO

GM

GO

HFS

HR

HSCP

HTR

IFAO

IJPT

JAC

JANER

JAOS

JEA	Annales du service des antiquités de l’Égypte
JEH	American Studies in Papyrology
JHS	Bulletin of the American Society of Papyrologists
JNES	Bibliothèque d’étude, IFAO
JRitSt	Bulletin de l’Institut d’Égypte
JRS	Le Bulletin de l’Institut français d’archéologie orientale
	Bulletin de la Société d’Egyptologie, Genève
	Bulletin de la Société française d’Égyptologie
	Beiträge zur Altertumskunde
	Coniectanea Biblica
	The Classical Bulletin
	Cahiers de la bibliothèque copte
	Chronique d’Égypte
	The Classical Journal
	Conjectanea Neotestamentica

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Volume 8

HERMES CHRISTIANUS

The Intermingling of Hermetic Piety and Christian Thought

by

Claudio Moreschini

Translated by Patrick Baker

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PREFACE

‘To trace the development of Hermetism across the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries by way of rigorous textual interpretation, to follow its various resonances on every level, would be, without a doubt, to contribute a singularly important chapter to the history of the epoch.’ Thus wrote Eugenio Garin in 1961, when indicating the importance for the subject of an even earlier study by Paul Oskar Kristeller (published in 1938). In the wake of Garin’s exhortation to deepen and broaden our understanding of Hermetism, it became the object of numerous studies, many of them excellent, that need not be listed here. Yet over time, the field of study has grown increasingly wider. Non-philosophical aspects (in the traditional sense) linked to the name of Trismegistus, such

as as-
trology, alchemy, and the so-called
‘pseudo sciences’, steadily gained in
importance.
Within so-called ‘philosophical’
Hermetism, on the other hand, as the
contours of
a Hebrew or an Arabic Hermetism became
ever more clearly defined, it was
realized that familiarity with Greek and
Latin texts did not suffice. Obviously,
the
comprehensive realization of the
enterprise urged by Garin has grown
increasingly
more difficult.

Aware of having to limit the scope of my
own study, I have thus decided to
focus on the way Christian philosophers
and theologians appropriated and then
elaborated Hermetic theosophy, not
Hermetic science. When speaking of
‘Hermes
Christianus’ one naturally thinks of a
non-Christian Hermes, the primordial
figure

in the history of Egypt who achieved renown beginning in the Hellenistic Age of Graeco-Roman antiquity. Numerous written sources testified to him, and equally numerous works were attributed to him from the second to the sixth centuries AD.

But with the Christianization of the late antique world, this distinction between Christian and non-Christian Hermetism naturally began to dissolve. Hence it is possible to write a comprehensive study of the place of Hermetism in Christian

writers of Late Antiquity; this becomes much more difficult for the Middle Ages and the Renaissance. I am aware, then, of not having been able to ‘follow its various resonances on every level’, as Garin had hoped. Therefore Hermes Christianus is not an impossible ‘history’ of Hermetism (such a history would have required the

same
dimensions as Thorndike's study of
magical and experimental science), but
an
attempt to enlarge our knowledge of
Hermetic religious philosophy. I am
quite
aware that many relevant individuals
have, for now, slipped through the 'net'
of my
study, and thus that its argument can at
times be impressionistic. Nonetheless I
am
convinced that the present volume serves
a useful function; readers may judge for
themselves.

I began my study of Hermetism almost
thirty years ago (in 1985) with the pub-
lication of Dall''Asclepius' al 'Crater
Hermetis': Studi sull'ermetismo latino
tardo-
antico e rinascimentale (Pisa:
Giardini), a volume that was well
received. The title
alone indicates my interests, and they
have remained constant down to the

present
volume. I later returned to the subject
in my Storia dell'ermetismo cristiano, pub-
lished by Morcelliana (Brescia) in 2000.
Unfortunately this book was given only
limited diffusion by the publisher;
meanwhile I continued to make contributions
to the study of Hermetism, as did many
others, and so it seemed wise to re-examine
my previous studies and bring them up to
date. Thus the present Hermes Chris-
tianus takes up certain problems I have
treated over the course of nearly three
decades and re-elaborates them,
sometimes radically.

The two books mentioned above have been
supplemented by the following
journal articles, here listed not
chronologically but according to the order of the
chapters of the present volume. For
Chapter 1: 'Soteria ermetica e soteria
cristiana:

affinità generiche e punti di contatto’, in Pagani e cristiani alla ricerca della salvezza (secoli I–III): XXXIV Incontro di studiosi dell’antichità cristiana Roma, 5–7 maggio 2005, Studia Ephemeridis Augustinianum, 96 (Rome: Augustinianum, 2006), pp. 261–74. For Chapter 4: ‘L’ermetismo del Rinascimento da Marsilio Ficino a Ludovico Lazzarelli’, Aries, 5 (2005), 33–60; ‘Ancora alcune considerazioni su Marsilio Ficino e l’ermetismo’, in Marsilio Ficino: Fonti, Testi, Fortuna, Atti del Convegno internazionale (Firenze, 1–3 ottobre 1999), ed. by S. Gentile and S. Toussaint (Rome: Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, 2006), pp. 89–120; ‘La poesia cristiana di Ludovico Lazzarelli: I Fasti Christianae Religionis’, Accademia, 5 (2003), 39–59. For Chapter 5: ‘Il commento al Corpus Hermeticum di François Foix-Candale: Annotazioni storiche e

filologiche’, Aries, 9 (2009), 37–58; ‘Il
commento al Pimandro di François Foix-Candalle: prime considerazioni’, in Anthropine Sophia: Studi di filologia e storiografia filosofica in memoria di Gabriele
Giannantoni, ed. by F. Alesse and others (Naples: Bibliopolis, 2008), pp. 551–60.

Finally, for Chapter 7: ‘Alla scoperta della vera identità degli scritti ermetici: il
contributo di Isaac Casaubon’, in Verités(s) philologiques(s): études sur les notions
de vérité et de fausseté en matière de philologie, ed. by P. Hummel and Fr. Gabriel
(Paris: Philologicum, 2008), pp. 207–19.

I would like to thank all of the publishers for giving me permission to reuse
portions of previously published material, and especially my friends and colleagues

Robert Dodaro, Sebastiano Gentile, Stéphane Toussaint, Wouter Hanegraaff, Francesca Alesse, and Pascale Hummel.

Special thanks go to James Hankins and Brian Copenhaver for having looked kindly on my proposal to publish the present volume, and for having found a place for it with the prestigious publisher Brepols. Thanks also to the copyeditor, Deborah A. Oosterhouse.

Patrick Baker, of the Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin, translated my Italian text into English. His was not a simple translation, though, but rather a true scholarly collaboration. Dr Baker discussed word choice with me with regard not only to proper English usage, but also to philosophical meaning. Furthermore, he helped me to identify oversights in the text and to correct them. To him and his philological precision I owe particular gratitude.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

For translations of the Corpus Hermeticum and Asclepius I have relied heavily on the English version of Brian Copenhaver (Hermetica, Cambridge University Press, 1992). Both direct quotations and paraphrases are based on his edition. It was often necessary to alter his rendering slightly in order to bring out the nuance desired by Professor Moreschini; such cases are too numerous to be noted with full consistency. Suffice it to say that all English translations of the Greek Corpus Hermeticum and Latin Asclepius are basically Copenhaver's, and that they are often slightly modified (although rarely with any significant difference in meaning).

All other Latin and Italian primary sources I have translated myself, in consul-
tation with Prof. Moreschini, except where noted. Bibliographical information about the primary sources used and about translations other than mine can be found in the Primary Sources section of the Select Bibliography. Translations of Greek primary sources were taken from existing editions, where possible, or based
on Prof. Moreschini's own Italian renderings (and again, in consultation with
him), where not. Translations of the Coptic texts of the Nag-Hammadi collection
are from The Nag-Hammadi Library, as noted.

Two words must be said with regard to Chapter 5, which is largely a paraphrase of Foix-Candale's Middle French commentary on the Corpus Hermeticum. First,
it contains a great deal of specialized

terminology which, having been translated into English by way of Prof. Moreschini's Italian (and not Candale's archaic French), can only be considered approximate; readers should bear in mind that they find themselves two steps removed from the original. Second, Candale is often long-winded and convoluted, and it has been impossible to avoid these shortcomings entirely in an English paraphrase while still respecting the primary imperative of fidelity to the text.

Translator's Notexii

Finally, a note of explanation regarding the use of the word 'demon' as a translation for daemon. Although it is common in translations of classical, pre-Christian texts to leave this term untranslated (e.g. Socrates' daemon), and

although this usage has grown
increasingly common for writings of the Christian
or Common Era as well, it has seemed
best to use the word ‘demon’ throughout,
and for two reasons: (1) it respects
this book’s specific focus on Christian thought;
and, similarly, (2) it highlights
connections, similarities, and dissimilarities – or
at least keeps such from being obscured
– between the various works discussed
over a period of about fifteen hundred
years. For example, to have Augustine talk
about ‘demons’ but Ficino daemones would
make it seem as if their texts had
different beings in mind, when in fact
such is rather improbable.

In closing, I would like to extend my
warmest thanks to Brian Copenhaver,
who readily and generously lent his
assistance on a few particularly troublesome
issues, and above all to Prof.

Moreschini for his patient consideration and explana-
tion of countless points of uncertainty.

P.B., Berlin

Chapter 1

PHILOSOPHICAL HERMETIC LITERATURE

Among the numerous writings of a religious nature from the second and third centuries AD,1 there are certain treatises that once enjoyed great fame and that even now pique our interest for many reasons. In them are found

the teaching of the Egyptian Hermes Trismegistus.2 They were assembled into a

1 This commonly accepted dating is valid for the final redaction of the Hermetic corpus: since
the various treatises are of a composite nature, they could date back even further; for example,
Plutarch (De Iside et Osiride 61. 375F) mentions a book of Hermes on the sacred names of Egypt
(see J.-P. Mahé, Hermès en Haute-Égypte,

vol. I: Les Textes hermétiques de Nag Hammadi et leurs
parallèles grecs et latins; vol. II: Le Fragment du ‘Discours parfait’ et les ‘Définitions’ hermétiques armé-
niennes (NH VI, 8.8a) (Quebec: Les Presses de l’Université Laval, 1978–82), II, 25–26). Further
ancient testimonies on Hermetism are provided by Diodorus Siculus (
The file is too long and its contents have been truncated.

TOOL

The file contents provided above are truncated/partial snippets. The complete content for these files IS accessible via querying.

If the user asks a question related to these files, and the provided snippets do not clearly answer it, you use the `file_search` tool to search the full document contents before responding.

If the user's query isn't sufficiently answered by the provided snippets, parsed text, or images, you should invoke `file_search.msearch`.
To search the full content of the available files, you send one message with recipient `to=file_search.msearch` in the analysis channel. Your message should be structured exactly as follows:

```
{
  'queries': ['Example query 1', 'Example query
2']  // List of up to five queries to search
for.
}
```

Carefully balance the number of `file_search` calls and the quality of your response with the latency incurred by `file_search` calls.

Important guidelines for query formatting:

- Your message must be a valid JSON object. Do not include any extraneous

text, backticks, markdown formatting, or comments beyond what is shown.

- The `queries` field must be a list of strings.

- One of the queries exactly match the user's original question, but stripped of any extraneous details, and with ambiguous references clearly resolved using context from the conversation. It be a complete sentence.

- Even if you suspect the user meant something else, one query still be their original question.

The file search tool will respond with the relevant search results from the full files. After you receive these results:

- Carefully evaluate each result to determine its relevance and quality.

- Use the high-quality and relevant results to inform your answer to the user's question.

- When possible, reuse information from prior file_search results and avoid repeating identical queries.

When the user asks a question, carefully consider whether the provided snippets sufficiently answer the query, whether you need to invoke `file_search.msearch`, or another available tool (such as `web`, if available) should be used instead.

Tool-ordering Guidelines:
1. For queries related to uploaded files, if snippets are insufficient, strongly prefer invoking `file_search.msearch` over other tools.
- Avoid using `web.run`, `python` analysis, or any other tools until you have either:
- Confirmed with high confidence the answer is not in the files, or
- Have high confidence `file_search_tool` queries are not sufficient to answer the query.
2. Avoid usage of `web_search/web.run` for queries related to uploaded files
- Carefully consider whether the user's query is better answered by web search

results rather than available snippets or results from `file_search_tool`.
- Unless the user's query is clearly unrelated to the uploaded files, prefer using `file_search.msearch`. You can always follow up with a web search if necessary for a more complete response.
3. Avoid using `python` unless necessary or requested by user.
- If the user's query is answerable from the parsed text and images from the uploaded files, or from `file_search_tool`, do not invoke `python`.

Always keep this instruction in mind for the rest of the conversation, as the user may reference these files or ask related questions later on.

TOOL

UNKNOWN

{"queries":["What is the current state of the art in scholarly comparison of Gnosticism and Hermeticism? --QDF=0","Hermetic tradition and mystery language connections to Nag Hammadi Gnostic texts","Discourse on the Eighth and the Ninth (NHC VI,6) comparison with Gnostic ascent and Sethianism","CH XIII rebirth ritual and parallels to Gnostic initiation","Sethian

Platonizing background and interactions with
Hermetic or Platonist circles"],
"source_filter":
["files_uploaded_in_conversation"]}

TOOL

[Web browsing]

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file0
Mclick Target: "1:0"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 245The Ritual of Rebirth
[L2]
[L3] quite a while, and has prepared himself by becoming a stranger to the world
[L4] and studying the Genikoi, referring

to a promise made by Hermes to teach him
[L5] the tradition of the rebirth. We do
not find a promise of rebirth made any-
[L6] where else in the Hermetica,
although as I have shown there are
several trea-
[L7] tises which reflect the process of
alienation from the world and
fortification
[L8] against its deception.
[L9]
[L10] An initiatory ritual may be
analyzed with the help of the tripartite
structure
[L11] suggested by the classic studies
of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner,
and
[L12] we should thus expect to find
elements reflecting separation,
liminality and
[L13] incorporation.4 As has been
pointed out by Mahé, an initiatory
structure is
[L14] much more evident in the Disc.8–9,
whereas CH XIII intersperses the initia-
[L15] tion proper with didactic
passages.5 However, unlike Mahé we shall

not con-
[L16] sider both the Disc.8–9 and CH XIII to be reflective of the Hermetic rebirth,
[L17] but rather as two distinct ritual stages of initiation.6 I will return to this point
[L18] when treating Disc.8–9. The first seven chapters of CH XIII are didactic, in ef-
[L19] fect summing up the procedure and doctrine of the rebirth.7 Then, in § 8, Tat
[L20] is instructed to keep a reverent silence, after which he is declared to be puri-
[L21] fied, and is filled with the powers of God (§§ 8–10). Tat then declares his vision
[L22] of himself in the All and in mind (§§ 11, 13) interspersed with explanatory pas-
[L23] sages of Hermes (§§ 12, 14). The rest of the treatise is concerned with the secret
[L24] hymn of the rebirth (§§ 15–16), which Hermes performs by means of his

pow-
[L25] ers (§§ 17–20), after which Tat also performs a short eulogy (§ 21), and finally
[L26] there is the oath of silence (§ 22). The general scheme of the treatise is thus:
[L27]
[L28] 1–7: Preparatory explanation of the procedure and doctrine of rebirth
[L29] 8: Call for reverent silence
[L30] 8–11: Tat receives the powers of God, invoked by Hermes
[L31] 11–12: Numerical explanation of punishers and powers
[L32] 13: Tat receives the vision of rebirth
[L33] 14: Hermes explains the imperishability of the new body of rebirth
[L34] 15–16: Tat requests the secret hymn of the rebirth
[L35] 16: Call for silence
[L36] 17–20: Secret Hymn
[L37]
[L38] 4 Arnold van Gennep, Les rites de passage (Paris: Emile Nourry, 1909);

Victor Turner, The Forest
[L39] of Symbols: Aspects of Ndembu
Rituals (Ithaca: Cornell University
Press, 1967).
[L40]
[L41] 5 HHE 1:44–47.
[L42] 6 Cf. Christian H. Bull,
“Gjenfødelse som innvielse i Hermes’
vei,” Dīn: Tidsskrift for Religion og
[L43]
[L44] Kultur 1–2 (2011): 7–21.
[L45] 7 CH XIII, 7: οὕτω συνίσταται ὁ
τῆς παλιγγενεσίας τρόπος καὶ λόγος.
[L46]
[L47]
[L48]
[L49] 246 Chapter 5
[L50]
[L51] 21: Eulogy of Tat
[L52] 22: Oath of silence8

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file1
Mclick Target: "1:1"
Content Snippet:
[L1] Metaphorically, the candidate
[L2] is a receptacle—a womb or a mixing-bowl—which must be cleansed before
[L3] it is filled with heavenly effluences.327 While formerly the passions of matter

[L4] flooded over him, he is now filled with divine powers that make him unassail-
[L5] able to further material avengers. The new human is now impervious to the
[L6] vicissitudes that befall his body, and the death of the body will merely entail
[L7] the release of the inner human, who can return reconstituted to his place of
[L8] origin above. But before that final ascent, the reborn human is also able to visit
[L9] these upper regions temporarily. This ascent is described in some detail in the
[L10] Discourse on the Eighth and the Ninth.
[L11]
[L12] 325 CH XIII, 20: ὁ σὸς ἄνθρωπος ταῦτα βοᾷ διὰ πυρός, δι’ ἀέρος, διὰ γῆς, διὰ ὕδατος, διὰ πνεύματος,
[L13] διὰ τῶν κτισμάτων σου.
[L14]
[L15] 326 Cf. now Pleše “Dualism in the Hermetic Writings,” 276.
[L16] 327 Cf. Eric R. Dodds, “New Light

on the ‘Chaldaean Oracles,’” HTR 54
(1961): 263–73 at 271: “In
[L17]
[L18] both [sc. the Chaldean Oracles and
Numenius], the human mind must make
itself empty
[L19] (κενεόν, Oracles, p. 11 K., the
ἐρημία of Numenius, fragm. 11) in order
to receive God.”
[L20]
[L21]
[L22]
[L23] © koninklijke brill nv, leiden,
2018 | doi:10.1163/9789004370845_008
[L24]
[L25] Chapter 6
[L26]
[L27] Heavenly Ascent: The Discourse on
the Eighth and
[L28] the Ninth (NHC VI,6)
[L29]
[L30] The importance of Disc.8–9 for
Hermetic studies can hardly be
overstated.
[L31] As the only text among the Nag
Hammadi Hermetica that was previously
un-

[L32] known, it came to light too late
to have any impact on the influential
magnum
[L33] opus of A.-J. Festugière, who
simply brushed aside what he apparently
saw as
[L34] an insignificant discovery of “une
jarre d’Égypte.”1 Due to the slow
process of
[L35] publication, it was only a
generation later that the text led
scholars such as
[L36] J.-P. Mahé and later Garth Fowden
to postulate a way of Hermes.
[L37]
[L38] Commentators soon noticed the
similarities between the present trea-
[L39] tise and On the Rebirth, and
concluded that the two texts were
different ver-
[L40] sions of essentially the same
phenomenon: spiritual regeneration.2 J.-
P. Mahé
[L41] is the scholar who has contributed
the most to advance our understanding
[L42] of the treatise, though his work
has focused mostly on the cosmology

underly-
[L43] ing the text. In his view, with
which we shall largely agree, the Decad
would
[L44] reflect the unbegotten sovereign
power of CH I, the Ennead is the noetic

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file2
Mclick Target: "1:2"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 1 My approach to ritual here is basically informed by Bell, Ritual Theory; Jonathan Z. Smith,
[L2] “The Bare Facts of Ritual,” History of Religions 20 (1980): 112–27; Stanley J. Tambiah, A

[L3] Performative Approach to Ritual (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1981); id., “The Magical
[L4] Power of Words,” Man 3 (1968): 175–208; John L. Austin, How to Do Things with Words
[L5] (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1975); John R. Searle, Speech Acts: An Essay in the
[L6] Philosophy of Language (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1969); id., Expression
[L7] and Meaning: Studies in the Theory of Speech Acts (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press,
[L8] 1979); Lawrence Sullivan, “Sound and Senses: Toward a Hermeneutic of Performance,”
[L9] Histroy of Religions 26 (1986): 1–33. On Lesemysterien cf. Reitzenstein, Die hellenistischen
[L10] Mysterienreligionen, 51–64, and critique in Fowden, The Egyptian Hermes, 149–50.
[L11]
[L12] 2 CH XIII, 3: εἰμι νῦν οὐχ ὁ πρίν.

[L13] 3 Cf. Karl-Wolfgang Tröger, Mysterienglaube und Gnosis in Corpus Hermeticum XIII (Berlin:
[L14]
[L15] Akademie-Verlag, 1971), 9–81; Christian H. Bull, “The Notion of Mysteries in the Formation of
[L16] Hermetic Tradition,” in Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient
[L17] Literature: Ideas and Practices (ed. Christian H. Bull, Liv I. Lied, and John D. Turner; NHMS 76;
[L18] Leiden: Brill, 2012), 399–426.
[L19]
[L20]
[L21]
[L22] 245The Ritual of Rebirth
[L23]
[L24] quite a while, and has prepared himself by becoming a stranger to the world
[L25] and studying the Genikoi, referring to a promise made by Hermes to teach him
[L26] the tradition of the rebirth. We do not find a promise of rebirth made

any-
[L27] where else in the Hermetica, although as I have shown there are several trea-
[L28] tises which reflect the process of alienation from the world and fortification
[L29] against its deception.
[L30]
[L31] An initiatory ritual may be analyzed with the help of the tripartite structure
[L32] suggested by the classic studies of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner, and
[L33] we should thus expect to find elements reflecting separation, liminality and
[L34] incorporation.4 As has been pointed out by Mahé, an initiatory structure is
[L35] much more evident in the Disc.8–9, whereas CH XIII intersperses the initia-
[L36] tion proper with didactic passages.5 However, unlike Mahé we shall not con-
[L37] sider both the Disc.8–9 and CH

XIII to be reflective of the Hermetic rebirth,
[L38] but rather as two distinct ritual stages of initiation.6 I will return to this point
[L39] when treating Disc.8–9. The first seven chapters of CH XIII are didactic, in ef-
[L40] fect summing up the procedure and doctrine of the rebirth.7 Then, in § 8, Tat
[L41] is instructed to keep a reverent silence, after which he is declared to be puri-
[L42] fied, and is filled with the powers of God (§§ 8–10).

Content source: Source.file
Title: Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinuss Mysticism (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies) (2020, BRILL) - libgen.li.pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file3
Mclick Target: "1:3"
Content Snippet:
[L1] Thus, despite the seeming
[L2] convolution of the texts, the extant Sethian evidence—with its greater empha-
[L3] sis on practical instruction and an (unabashedly mythopoetic) articulation of
[L4] micro-phases—provides a lucid

glimpse of a conception of ascent that these
[L5] sectaries apparently shared with Plotinus.
[L6]
[L7] 1.1 The Situation of the Platonizing Ascent Treatises in the Context of
[L8] Sethian Gnosticism and Middle Platonism
[L9]
[L10] The Platonizing Sethian treatises Zostrianos and Allogenes—along with the
[L11] related tractates Three Steles of Seth (NHC VII,5) and Marsanes (NHC X,1)—
[L12] comprise what John Turner has called the “ascent pattern” treatises, and
[L13] they reflect a specific, and apparently later, moment in the development of
[L14] Sethianism. During this period, the Sethians had apparently distanced them-
[L15] selves from their original Jewish-baptismal and / or superficially Christian

[L16] forebears and were attempting to integrate themselves into Platonic philo-
[L17] sophical circles.3 In the earlier Sethian treatises of the “descent pattern,”4 a
[L18] divine revealer or savior who is usually some modality of Barbelo—the second
[L19] principle—makes a successive series of descents in order to impart gnōsis and
[L20] thus rescue humankind—or an elect “race” (genos) or subset of humans5—
[L21] from their terrestrial or cosmic prison.6 The ascent treatises, by contrast, pur-
[L22] port to be first-person accounts by eponymous human aspirants who have
[L23] themselves ascended through various celestial and metaphysical strata so as
[L24]
[L25] 3 Turner has hypothesized the complex vicissitudes of the Sethian movement; see Turner 1986;
[L26] 2001, 747–59. On the tenuous

relationship of the Sethian corpus with Christianity, see
[L27] Schenke 1981; on the relationship to Judaism, see also, inter alia, Turner 1998; Pearson 1990,
[L28] 124–35; Schenke 1981.
[L29]
[L30] 4 E.g., the Ap. John (NHC II,1, III,1, IV,1, and BG,2), Three Forms (NHC XIII,1*), and Gos. Eg. / Holy
[L31] Book of the Great Invisible Spirit (NHC III,2 and IV,2).
[L32]
[L33] 5 Such as the Sethians, who apparently identified themselves as the spiritual lineage of the
[L34] biblical Seth, son of Adam.
[L35]
[L36] 6 Turner suggests that the “descent pattern” derives from Hellenistic Jewish Wisdom literature;
[L37] on the two patterns, see Turner 2001, 80–84, 93–125; 2002.
[L38]
[L39]
[L40]
[L41] 142 chapter 4

[L42]
[L43] to apprehend and / or unite with the transcendental principle(s).7 Broadly
[L44] speaking, the language is typical of the apocalyptic genre,8 but the Platonizing
[L45] Sethian ascent treatises simultaneously echo Plato’s conception of a meta-
[L46] physical realm of eternal realities (the Forms), as well as the philosophical ‘as-
[L47] cent’ towards, and apprehension of, a transcendent principle akin to Plato’s
[L48] Good,9 while simultaneously reflecting other philosophical influences; this
[L49] includes a certain amount of Stoic and Aristotelian language as well as evi-
[L50] dence of familiarity with the elaborate negative theological speculations that
[L51] developed within the early Academy and flourished in Middle Platonism (as

[L52] well as second-century
Gnosticism).10 Perhaps more importantly,
these texts
[L53] imply that such an ascent could be
ritually replicated, either communally
or
[L54] individually,

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file4
Mclick Target: "1:4"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 109 Kevin van Bladel, The Arabic Hermes: From Pagan Sage to Prophet of Science (Oxford:
[L2] Oxford University Press, 2009), 17–22.
[L3]

[L4] 110 Moreschini, Hermes
Christianus, chap. 2.
[L5] 111 Ibid., 160.
[L6]
[L7]
[L8]
[L9] 28 CHAPTER 1
[L10]
[L11] that Iamblichus may have been
initiated into Hermetism on a trip to
Egypt.112
[L12] Although this cannot be proven, it
is not inherently unlikely, and it is
possible
[L13] that Iamblichus had a foot in many
different cults and philosophical
circles, a
[L14] common phenomenon cross-culturally
in what Colin Campbell refers to as the
[L15] “cultic milieu.”113
[L16]
[L17] Another contemporary religious
current, to which many earlier schol-
[L18] ars have related Hermetism, is
that which has been dubbed Gnosticism.
[L19] Hermetism has indeed often been
referred to as a form of “pagan

Gnosticism.”114
[L20] The term “Gnosticism” has been much criticized in the last decades, and many
[L21] scholars now follow Michael Williams and Karen King in discarding the term,115
[L22] while others still see a use for it.116 I will not enter into this debate here, only
[L23] notice that while Hermetic texts may fruitfully be compared with texts usually
[L24] designated Gnostic, there has been a tendency to make inferences regarding
[L25] Hermetism based on highly uncertain presuppositions taken from the catego-
[L26] ry “Gnosticism.” One example, pointed out by Tage Petersen, is the postulate
[L27] in scholarly literature of a Hermetic dualism, which has largely been inferred
[L28] from the presupposition of a Gnostic dualism.117 For this reason, I will largely

[L29] avoid using “Gnosticism” as a comparandum.
[L30]
[L31] Likewise, although the Jewish influence on some Hermetic texts has been
[L32] demonstrated—though possibly exaggerated—by such prominent scholars as
[L33] C.H. Dodd, Birger Pearson, and Marc Philonenko, mainly on the basis of resem-
[L34] blances to Septuagint motifs and language, we shall not enter into the question
[L35]
[L36] 112 Polymnia Athanassiadi, La lutte pour l’orthodoxie dans le platonisme tardif: De Numénius à
[L37] Damascius (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 2006), 162–66.
[L38]
[L39] 113 Colin Campbell, “The Cult, the Cultic Milieu and Secularization,” in The Cultic Milieu:
[L40] Oppositional Subcultures in an Age of Globalization (ed. Jeffrey Kaplan and

Heléne Lööw;
[L41] Walnut Creek: Altamira, 2002), 12–
25.
[L42]
[L43] 114 Cf. Fowden, The Egyptian
Hermes, 113–15.
[L44] 115 Michael A. Williams,
Rethinking “Gnosticism”: An Argument for
Dismantling a Dubious
[L45]
[L46] Category (Princeton: Princeton
University Press, 1996); Karen L. King,
What Is Gnosticism?
[L47] (Cambridge: Belknap Press of
Harvard University Press, 2003). Cf.
Morton Smith, “The
[L48] History of the Term Gnostikos,” in
The Rediscovery of Gnosticism II:
Sethian Gnosticism (ed.
[L49] Bentley Layton; Leiden: Brill,
1981), 796–807.
[L50]
[L51] 116 E.g., David Brakke, The
Gnostics: Myth, Ritual, and Diversity in
Early Christianity
[L52] (Cambridge: Harvard University
Press, 2010).

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Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file5
Mclick Target: "1:5"
Content Snippet:
[L1] Rejoice, new light!”136 Grese’s
[L2] objection against this parallel, that the initiation in CH XIII is not complete
[L3] at this point, is invalid. Disc.8–9 clearly demonstrates that the rejoicing

can
[L4] occur in the midst of visionary experience, and furthermore, our source for the
[L5] Mithraic formula, Firmicus Maternus, does not provide the full context, so we
[L6] cannot know where in the ritual proceedings it would have occurred. The best
[L7] way to make sense of the ritual sequence, in my view, is thus to assume that
[L8] the two first stages of the rebirth proper would be, first, ritual silence, in which
[L9]
[L10] 130 CH XVI, 15–16; cf. CH XII, 19.
[L11] 131 Scott 1:244.
[L12] 132 CH XIII, 9: δύναμιν καλῶ ἐπὶ χαρᾷ τὴν ἐγκράτειαν.
[L13] 133 NHC vi 57,28–30: ⲣⲁϣⲉ ⲉϫⲙ ⲡⲁⲓ̈· ⲏⲇⲏ ⲅⲁⲣ ⲉⲃⲟⲗ ⲙ̄ⲙⲟⲟⲩ ⲧⲇⲩⲛⲁⲙⲓⲥ ⲉⲧⲟ ⲛ̄ⲟⲩⲟⲉⲓⲛ ⲛ̄ⲛⲏⲩ
[L14]
[L15] ϣⲁⲣⲟⲛ· Cf. comment in HHE 1:111.

[L16] 134 NHC VI 58,24–31: ϯⲕⲁⲣⲁⲉⲓⲧ … ϯⲣ̄ⲛⲟⲉⲓ ⲙ̄ⲡⲛⲟⲩⲥ … ϯⲣⲁϣⲉ.

[L17] 135 NHC vi 64,15–19: ⲧⲛ̄ⲣⲁϣⲉ ⲛ̄ⲧⲁⲣⲛ̄ϫⲓ ⲟⲩⲟⲉⲓⲛ ϩⲛ̄ ⲧⲉⲕⲅⲛⲱⲥⲓⲥ· ⲧⲛ̄ⲣⲁϣⲉ ϫⲉ ⲁⲕⲧⲥⲉⲃⲟⲛ ⲉⲣⲟⲕ·

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Title: Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinuss Mysticism (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies) (2020, BRILL) - libgen.li.pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file6
Mclick Target: "1:6"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 1 The more general similarities and differences between Plotinus and the Gnostics have been
[L2] the subject of a substantial body of literature (citations in the Introduction, Ch. 1); this topic
[L3] extends far beyond the scope of this chapter, which is restricted to a

discussion of the final
[L4] stages of mystical ascent and the apprehension of the supreme principle.
[L5]
[L6] 2 The revelatory discourse is usually framed as initiatory instruction from one or another of
[L7] the quasi-divine revealers that populate the Sethian universe, although there are exception-
[L8] al cases in which the revelation-discourse is presented in terms of philosophical dialectic
[L9] and / or scholastic pedagogy, further blurring the categorical distinction between Platonic
[L10] and Sethian rhetorical mode; thus a passage of Zostrianos (22.2–23.20) even implies that one
[L11] undergoes a series of metaphorical ablutions that seem to correspond to progressive mastery
[L12] of ever more complex aspects of Aristotle’s theory of categories, using the language of “uni-
[L13] versal” (katholikos), “partial” (merikos), “species” (eidos), and

“genus” (genos).
[L14]
[L15]
[L16]
[L17] 141“The Way of Ascent is the Way of Descent”
[L18]
[L19] principles, but in certain cases reify them into quasi-hypostases themselves,
[L20] thus articulating otherwise unutterable, eternal processes in terms of a pro-
[L21] fusion of mythical-seeming personalities. Indeed, the Sethian tendency to
[L22] subdivide, multiply, and hypostatize intermediary principles is diametrically
[L23] opposite to—and in fact the likely target of—Plotinus’s dogmatic rejection of
[L24] intermediaries (at, for example, II.9[33].1). Unconstrained by rigid axioms con-
[L25] cerning the relation of the first and second principle, the Platonizing

Sethians
[L26] were able to articulate the complex transitional or interhypostatic phases of
[L27] ontogenesis and mystical return in lavish detail. Thus, despite the seeming
[L28] convolution of the texts, the extant Sethian evidence—with its greater empha-
[L29] sis on practical instruction and an (unabashedly mythopoetic) articulation of
[L30] micro-phases—provides a lucid glimpse of a conception of ascent that these
[L31] sectaries apparently shared with Plotinus.
[L32]
[L33] 1.1 The Situation of the Platonizing Ascent Treatises in the Context of
[L34] Sethian Gnosticism and Middle Platonism
[L35]
[L36] The Platonizing Sethian treatises Zostrianos and Allogenes—along with the
[L37] related tractates Three Steles of

Seth (NHC VII,5) and Marsanes (NHC X,1)—
[L38] comprise what John Turner has
called the “ascent pattern” treatises,
and
[L39] they reflect a specific, and
apparently later, moment in the
development of
[L40] Sethianism. During this period,
the Sethians had apparently distanced
them-
[L41] selves from their original Jewish-
baptismal and / or superficially
Christian
[L42] forebears and were attempting to
integrate themselves into Platonic
philo-
[L43] sophical circles.3 In the earlier
Sethian treatises of the “descent
pattern,”4 a
[L44] divine revealer or savior who is
usually some modality of Barbelo—the
second
[L45] principle—makes a successive
series of descents in order to impart
gnōsis and
[L46] thus rescue humankind—or an elect
“race” (genos) or subset of humans5—

[L47] from their terrestrial or cosmic prison.6 The ascent treatises, by contrast, pur-
[L48] port to be first-person accounts by eponymous human aspirants who have
[L49] themselves ascended through various celestial and metaphysical strata so as

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Mclick Target: "1:7"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 50 In Mazur 2005 I have expressed my views on Plotinus’s philosophical opposition to the
[L2] Gnostics.
[L3]
[L4] 51 Uncommitted to any particular tradition of scriptural or philosophical interpretation, the

[L5] Gnostics made no attempt to harmonize incongruities in their various source-texts, but
[L6] rather foregrounded inconsistencies as contrapuntal fodder for theological speculation.
[L7] This is close to Couliano’s 1992 interpretation; see also Williams 1992a.
[L8]
[L9]
[L10]
[L11] 16 chapter 1
[L12]
[L13] template for salvation than with the rational justification of a metaphysical
[L14] system. But even granting differences of these sorts, these two types of com-
[L15] munity may be understood to have shared a common thought-world, if not al-
[L16] ways a common self-identification, and it was this shared thought-world itself
[L17] that would have provided a fixed point of agreement in relation to which

spe-
[L18] cific issues could be debated.52 As is by now well known, there have been sub-
[L19] stantial challenges to the very category of ‘Gnosticism’ itself;53 but even if one
[L20] retains the category in the broadest sense—as, I believe, is unavoidable54—its
[L21] precise conceptual and socio-historical contours are far more ambiguous than
[L22] has usually been imagined. As I will suggest in the conclusion, no absolute
[L23] categorical boundary can be drawn between ‘Gnosticism’ and ‘Platonism’ in
[L24] the period before Plotinus’s circle made the debate with the Gnostics a cause
[L25] célèbre; and they did so, I suggest, not so much because of doctrinal disagree-
[L26] ment, but simply because of the putative association of these sectaries with

[L27] the threat to traditional
‘Hellenic’ philosophy presented by the
sudden bur-
[L28] geoning of Christianity in mid
third-century Rome.
[L29]
[L30] 4 The Current State of the
Research
[L31]
[L32] 4.1 The Status Quaestionis
[L33] Until the full publication of the
Nag Hammadi corpus in the late 1970s,
the
[L34] possibility of substantial cross-
fertilization between Plotinus and the
Gnostics
[L35] had rarely been entertained.
Despite the 1964 publication of Hans-
Joachim
[L36] Krämer’s Der Ursprung der
Geistmetaphysik—which situated Gnostic
(primari-
[L37] ly Valentinian) protology in the
context of Middle Platonic and
Neopythagorean
[L38] speculation on derivational
schemata—it was often not even admitted

that
[L39] Gnosticism itself had a serious philosophical content, let alone any influence
[L40] on academic philosophy. As recently as 1978, A. H. Armstrong could write
[L41] that the influence of Greek philosophy as a whole upon Gnosticism is "not
[L42]
[L43] 52 Consider Cornford's observation (1950, 29): "No dispute can be carried on unless both par-
[L44] ties have some fundamental standpoint on which they agree. This common basis is the
[L45] last thing of which they are likely to be aware. Hence in the philosophic debate it is apt to
[L46] pass almost wholly unmentioned."
[L47]
[L48] 53 Various recent corrective attempts, most prominently those of Williams 1996 and
[L49] K. King 2003, have succeeded in questioning the negative evaluation of

Gnosticism pri-
[L50] marily by calling the whole
category itself into question, either by
dissolving it into a
[L51] broader, more pluralistic notion
of Christianity (King) or by
reclassifying it as a special
[L52] kind of biblical mythology
(Williams).
[L53]
[L54] 54 With Pearson 2004, 201–23.
[L55]
[L56]
[L57]
[L58] 17Introduction

Content source: Source.file
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Citation Marker: filecite turn1file8
Mclick Target: "1:8"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 4 The Current State of the Research
[L2]
[L3] 4.1 The Status Quaestionis
[L4] Until the full publication of the Nag Hammadi corpus in the late 1970s, the
[L5] possibility of substantial cross-fertilization between Plotinus and the

Gnostics
[L6] had rarely been entertained.
Despite the 1964 publication of Hans-
Joachim
[L7] Krämer’s Der Ursprung der
Geistmetaphysik—which situated Gnostic
(primari-
[L8] ly Valentinian) protology in the
context of Middle Platonic and
Neopythagorean
[L9] speculation on derivational
schemata—it was often not even admitted
that
[L10] Gnosticism itself had a serious
philosophical content, let alone any
influence
[L11] on academic philosophy. As
recently as 1978, A. H. Armstrong could
write
[L12] that the influence of Greek
philosophy as a whole upon Gnosticism is
“not
[L13]
[L14] 52 Consider Cornford’s
observation (1950, 29): “No dispute can
be carried on unless both par-
[L15] ties have some fundamental

standpoint on which they agree. This common basis is the
[L16] last thing of which they are likely to be aware. Hence in the philosophic debate it is apt to
[L17] pass almost wholly unmentioned.”
[L18]
[L19] 53 Various recent corrective attempts, most prominently those of Williams 1996 and
[L20] K. King 2003, have succeeded in questioning the negative evaluation of Gnosticism pri-
[L21] marily by calling the whole category itself into question, either by dissolving it into a
[L22] broader, more pluralistic notion of Christianity (King) or by reclassifying it as a special
[L23] kind of biblical mythology (Williams).
[L24]
[L25] 54 With Pearson 2004, 201–23.
[L26]
[L27]
[L28]
[L29] 17Introduction

[L30]
[L31] genuine, but extraneous, and, for the most part superficial.”55 Today, however,
[L32] in the light of the publication of the complete edition of the Nag Hammadi
[L33] corpus and a number of important studies and colloquia, this is no longer a
[L34] tenable position.56 More recent scholarship has gradually begun to take the
[L35] interaction between Greek philosophy and Gnosticism seriously, and in the
[L36] past three decades it has become increasingly evident that the major currents
[L37] of Gnosticism were closely interwoven with the academic Middle Platonism
[L38] and Neopythagoreanism of the first two centuries of this era, particularly in
[L39] regard to doctrines of first principles and the transcendental interpretations

[L40] of Platonic metaphysics. Indeed, not only does it now appear that Gnosticism
[L41] is permeated with Greek philosophy, but a number of recent studies have sug-
[L42] gested that specific aspects of Gnostic thought were influential in philosophi-
[L43] cal circles and that Plotinus derived a number of features of his thought from
[L44] his encounter with Gnostics in his immediate milieu.57 Over the past two de-
[L45] cades, the joint work of John Turner and Kevin Corrigan has suggested that
[L46] the Platonizing Sethians were situated on the cusp of certain central debates
[L47] within the academic-philosophical milieu and that they may even have caused
[L48] Plotinus to revise some of his positions in light of Gnostic ideas.58 This mono-

[L49] graph attempts to build on this important but still nascent body of scholarship
[L50] and simultaneously address hitherto neglected aspects of Plotinian mysticism.
[L51]
[L52] 4.2 The Problem of the Relative Chronology of Plotinus and the
[L53] Platonizing Sethians: A Brief History of the Debate

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Citation Marker: filecite turn1file9
Mclick Target: "1:9"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 61 If they did so, we may wonder why. According to the hypotheses of Turner 2001 and now
[L2] Rasimus 2010, the Sethians gradually moved into the orbit of Academic Platonism after
[L3]
[L4]

[L5]
[L6] 247Conclusion: Dissolving Boundaries
[L7]
[L8] with the arrival of Porphyry, and obligated Plotinus to refute them in the
[L9] Großschrift; but quite plainly Porphyry does not say, as is often claimed, that
[L10] Gnostic sectaries ever attended Plotinus’s classes. Indeed, the prevalence of
[L11] the erroneous interpretation has encouraged the implausible (if not utterly
[L12] preposterous) notion that the Vorlagen of the extant Coptic translations of
[L13] Platonizing Sethian tractates were not those read in Plotinus’s circle but were
[L14] newer versions that had been revised by Plotinus’s putative Gnostic auditors to
[L15] take Plotinus’s (and Porphyry’s) critiques into account. In any event, whether or

[L16] not these Gnostics were ever physically present, one thing of which we can be
[L17] certain is that their treatises circulated readily among Plotinus's entourage.62
[L18]
[L19] But there is also another, stronger possibility: could these unnamed philoi,
[L20] for whom Plotinus still has some reverence, in fact refer to certain Gnostic as-
[L21] sociates from Plotinus's Alexandrian past, or even to Ammonius himself and /
[L22] or members of his entourage? That Plotinus's anti-Gnostic writings are not di-
[L23] rected at the Gnostics themselves is indicated by his occasional addresses to
[L24] his readers in II.9[33] with the second person, while the Gnostics are always
[L25] referred to in the third person, and with a kind of rhetorical vitriol

that one
[L26] would not expect him to use if the target—his friends—were in his immediate
[L27] presence. In fact he is explicit that this discourse is not for the Gnostics but for
[L28] his immediate pupils; thus immediately after mentioning his Gnostic philoi,
[L29] he insists: “We have spoken to [our] intimate pupils (gnōrimous), not to them
[L30] [i.e., the Gnostics].”63 This possibility that he is referring to Ammonius’s circle
[L31] becomes more intriguing if we note that one of the few other places where
[L32] Plotinus evokes this kind of hesitation and self-restraint is at the conclusion
[L33] of his furtive discussion of intelligible matter—also, as we have seen, conceiv-
[L34] ably an Ammonian doctrine—at II.4[12].5.37–39: “And by this, more than is
[L35] appropriate has been revealed

about intelligible matter.”64 Both passages—the
[L36]
[L37] a gradual estrangement from Christian circles. The real question, however, if indeed they
[L38] did attend Plotinus’s seminar, why would they choose him in particular?
[L39]
[L40] 62 It is possible these treatises were deliberately circulated by these sectaries to prosely-
[L41] tize their own views or to lure away Plotinus’s students. That such writings were easily
[L42] accessible to the students is evident not only from Porphyry Vit. Plot. 16 but also from
[L43] Plotinus’s casual suggestion, at the conclusion of an exasperated diatribe about Gnostic
[L44] demonology in II.9[33].14, that his students investigate the remainder of their doctrines
[L45] for themselves.

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Title: (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull, Liv Ingeborg Lied, John D. Turner - Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient Literature_ Ideas and Practices. Stu.pdf
Citation Marker: filecite turn1file10
Mclick Target: "1:10"
Content Snippet:
[L1] 9 Giulia Sfameni Gasparro, “La gnosi ermetica come iniziazione e mistero,” SMSR 36

[L2] (1965): 43–62. However, Gasparro
later admits, in Soteriology and Mystic
Aspects, xvii, that
[L3] “the classifijicatory scheme of the
‘dying and rising god’ . . . has turned
out to be inadequate
[L4] for the defijinition of the varied
and multiple historical reality of the
facts examined.” This
[L5] extends also to the question of
salvation.
[L6]
[L7] 10 Tröger, Mysterienglaube, 21 and
51.
[L8] 11 Fowden, The Egyptian Hermes,
149–50.
[L9] 12 Smith, Drudgery Divine, 34, 65,
and 67.
[L10]
[L11]
[L12]
[L13] 402 christian h. bull
[L14]
[L15] focus predominantly on CH XIII,
because it has to do with rebirth, sup-
[L16] posedly a core element of mystery
religion. However, this text is meager

in
[L17] mystery language, containing
little of its vocabulary. In the
following, we
[L18] shall keep the presumptions of
what constitutes “true” mysteries at
bay,
[L19] and rather focus on how the texts
employ the word.
[L20]
[L21] According to Walter Burkert, there
is an inflation of the terms mystêria
[L22] and mystikos in Gnostic and
Hermetic texts, causing a corresponding
[L23] devaluation of meaning.13 A
lexicographical survey of words cognate
to
[L24] mystêrion and myeô in the
Hermetica yields a total of 26
instances: Nine in
[L25] the Stobaeic fragment Korê kosmou
(SH XXIII), another three in SH XXV,
[L26] two in FH 23 and one each in CH I,
V, XIV and XVI. Another six instances
[L27] of mysterium appear in the Latin
Asclepius, along with two in the Coptic
[L28] fragment unattested in the

Latin.14 Other mystery terms are sparse. Teletê
[L29] does not appear at all, and teleô and its derivates appear uniformly in
[L30] the sense of completion, not initiation.15 Despite Burkert, this is not such
[L31] an impressive profusion of terms, and it should be possible to evaluate if
[L32] there is indeed a devaluation of meaning.
[L33]
[L34] Straightaway, the fact that there are no instances of the word in the
[L35] more initiatory texts should give us pause, namely On the rebirth (CH XIII)
[L36] and Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth (NHC VI, 6), along with only one
[L37] instance in that central text, the Poimandres (CH I).16 Our main focus will
[L38] thus naturally be the two texts where the terms mystêria and mysterium
[L39] abound, namely the Korê kosmou17 (hereafter KK) and the Asclepius.
[L40]
[L41] Korê kosmou: Isis' treatise to

Horus (SH XXIII)
[L42]
[L43] Consistent with its multiple invocations of mystêria, the KK expounds at
[L44] some length about the pedigree of the Hermetic traditio mystica. At one
[L45]
[L46] 13 Burkert, Mystery Cults, 86.
[L47] 14 Louis Delatte, Suzanne Govaerts, and Joseph Denooz, Index du Corpus Hermeticum
[L48]
[L49] (Roma: Ateneo & Bizzarri, 1977), 121 and 310.
[L50] 15 Ibid., 180. epoptês appears only in SH XXIII, and then not in its mystery-sense, see
[L51]
[L52] below.
[L53] 16 The Byzantine manuscript tradition of the Corpus Hermeticum may have undergone

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Citation Marker: filecite turn1file11
Mclick Target: "1:11"
Content Snippet:
[L1] This idea does not seem to be
[L2] attested elsewhere in John. (It is not identical with the claim that Jesus

“comes from above,”
[L3] as stated in John 3:31.) In
addition, Meeks’s theory fijits ill with
John 3:8, where Jesus speaks
[L4] of “everyone who is born from
spirit.”
[L5]
[L6] 29 “I am entirely at a loss”, “You
have driven me quite mad, father,” “I
have gone mad,”
[L7] CH XIII, 2, 4, 6.
[L8]
[L9] 30 Cf. Jerome H. Neyrey, The Gospel
of John (NCBC; Cambridge: Cambridge
University
[L10] Press, 2007), 77. Scholars are
divided over the issue whether other
passages in John men-
[L11] tioning Nicodemus imply his
progress in faith or not; for a recent
discussion of difffer-
[L12] ent positions, see Raimo Hakola,
“The Burden of Ambiguity: Nicodemus and
the Social
[L13]
[L14]
[L15]

[L16] secrecy in the gospel of john 233
[L17]
[L18] Rebirth itself is imagined
diffferently in John 3 and CH XIII. What
takes
[L19] place during rebirth, according to
the latter, is the complete change of
[L20] one’s mindset which results in a
new way of looking at the world. Prior
[L21] to rebirth, Tat’s inner self is
subject to twelve “torments,” which are
men-
[L22] tal states and dispositions (e.g.,
ignorance, pain, envy, desire, greed and
[L23] anger). Rebirth takes place when
God provides the student with ten pow-
[L24] ers (e.g., knowledge, joy,
perseverance) that drive away the mind’s
twelve
[L25] torments for good. After this, the
student’s mind becomes fijilled with
[L26] truth, goodness, life and light
(CH XIII, 9–10), and he no longer sees
with
[L27] his physical eyes but with his
“mind’s eye” (14). Rebirth, thus, is
envisioned

[L28] in intellectual terms; the only
“ritual” involved is the hymn of praise
to be
[L29] presented in honor of the creator-
God (17–18).
[L30]
[L31] Jesus in John 3 is far less
specifijic as to what happens in rebirth.
One
[L32] learns that, as a spiritual birth,
rebirth is contrasted to physical birth
(3:6),
[L33] and that the origin and goal of
the reborn person remain unknown (at
[L34] least to Nicodemus, 3:8).
Moreover, ritual plays a role in
rebirth: it is a birth
[L35] “from water and the Spirit” (3:5).
This implies that baptism plays a role
in
[L36] rebirth,31 although it is not
explained how. This point separates John
from
[L37] CH XIII where a baptismal ritual
is not connected with rebirth. However,
[L38] the combination of water, spirit,
and intellectual rebirth occurs in the

so-
[L39] called Mithras Liturgy (PGM IV. 475–820), which “seems to reflect an early
[L40] or nascent Hermeticism of the fijirst and the second century c.e.”32 One
[L41] crucial diffference between the Mithras Liturgy and the treatises in Corpus
[L42] Hermeticum is precisely that the former invests “in the actual practice of
[L43] ritual,” while the latter “drop the ritual and fully internalize and spiritualize

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Citation Marker: filecite turn1file12
Mclick Target: "1:12"
Content Snippet:
[L1] ⲙ̅ⲛ̅ⲧⲉⲥ ⲁ̀ⲣⲭⲏ.
[L2] 106 Ascl. 6: feliciore loco medietatis est positus.

[L3] 107 NHC VI 61,15–63,32.

[L4] 108 NHC VI 63,9–11: ⲕⲁⲧⲁ ⲃⲁⲑⲙⲟⲥ ⲉϥⲙⲟⲟⲩϣⲉ ⲉϥⲛ̅ⲛ̅ⲏⲩ ⲉϩⲟⲩⲛ ⲉⲑⲓⲏ ⲛ̅ⲧ̅ⲙ̅ⲛ̅ⲧ̅ⲁⲧⲙⲟⲩ.

[L5]

[L6]

[L7]

[L8] the notion of mysteries 423

[L9]

[L10] Bidez, Joseph and Franz Cumont. Les mages hellénisés: Zoroastre, Ostanès et Hystaspe

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Citation Marker: 【filecite】turn1file13【
Mclick Target: "1:13"
Content Snippet:
[L1] Another six instances
[L2] of mysterium appear in the Latin Asclepius, along with two in the Coptic

[L3] fragment unattested in the Latin.14
Other mystery terms are sparse. Teletê
[L4] does not appear at all, and teleô
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[L7] there is indeed a devaluation of
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[L11] and Discourse on the Eighth and
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[L12] instance in that central text, the
Poimandres (CH I).16 Our main focus will
[L13] thus naturally be the two texts
where the terms mystêria and mysterium
[L14] abound, namely the Korê kosmou17
(hereafter KK) and the Asclepius.
[L15]
[L16] Korê kosmou: Isis' treatise to

Horus (SH XXIII)
[L17]
[L18] Consistent with its multiple invocations of mystêria, the KK expounds at
[L19] some length about the pedigree of the Hermetic traditio mystica. At one
[L20]
[L21] 13 Burkert, Mystery Cults, 86.
[L22] 14 Louis Delatte, Suzanne Govaerts, and Joseph Denooz, Index du Corpus Hermeticum
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[L24] (Roma: Ateneo & Bizzarri, 1977), 121 and 310.
[L25] 15 Ibid., 180. epoptês appears only in SH XXIII, and then not in its mystery-sense, see
[L26]
[L27] below.
[L28] 16 The Byzantine manuscript tradition of the Corpus Hermeticum may have undergone
[L29]
[L30] Christian censorship. Cf. Jean-Pierre Mahé, Hermès en Haute-Égypte (2 vols.; BCNH.T 3 &

[L31] 7; Québec: Les Presses de l’Université Laval, 1978–1982), 1:24.
[L32]
[L33] 17 I opt here to keep the title untranslated, due to the fact that both “maiden” and
[L34] “pupil” (of the eye) have been suggested as translations for Korê. Furthermore, it might be
[L35] a reference to the protagonist, Isis. Cf. Howard M. Jackson, “Κόρη κόσμου: Isis, Pupil of the
[L36] Eye of the World,” CdE 61 (1986): 116–35. In the following, the translations of SH and FH are
[L37] my own, while those of CH and Ascl. belong to Brian Copenhaver, Hermetica (Cambridge:
[L38] Cambridge University Press, 1992).
[L39]
[L40]
[L41]
[L42] the notion of mysteries 403
[L43]
[L44] point in the lengthy discourse of Isis in the KK, she is about to tell her son

[L45] Horus about the incarnation of souls, and admonishes him:

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[L1] Sufffijicient proof of this should be that in the Discourse of
[L2] the Eighth and the Ninth, just

after Tat has achieved divinity, Hermes asks
[L3] him to go to his temple in Diospolis and write down the discourse on a
[L4] hieroglyphic stele. This should be set up at a specifijic astrological conjunc-
[L5] tion, and has a protective curse put on it, conjuring amongst others the
[L6] seven ousiarchs of heaven who also appear in Ascl. 19 in connection with
[L7] the heavenly mysteries.107 The books should thereafter only be accessible
[L8] to those who “going step by step arrive onto the way of immortality.”108
[L9]
[L10] Bibliography
[L11]
[L12] Berthelot, Marcellin. Collection des anciens alchimistes grecs. 3 vols. Paris: Georges Steinheil,
[L13] 1887–1888.
[L14]
[L15] Betz, Hans Dieter. “Magic and Mystery in the Greek Magical Papyri.”

Pages 244–59 in
[L16] Magika Hiera: Ancient Greek Magic and Religion. Edited by Christopher A. Faraone and
[L17] Dirk Obbink. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991.
[L18]
[L19] 103 The exception is FH 23, dealing with the intellectual light (φῶς νοερὸν), which how-
[L20] ever “always embraces all things with its intellect and light and spirit.” (ἀεὶ τῷ ἑαυτοῦ νοῖ
[L21] καὶ φωτὶ καὶ πνεύματι πάντα περιέχει.)
[L22]
[L23] 104 CH XIII, 13: τὸ πᾶν ὁρῶ καὶ ἐμαυτὸν ἐν τῷ νοῖ.
[L24] 105 NHC VI 58,10–13: ⲁⲛⲟⲕ ⲁⲉⲓⲃⲛ̅ ⲧⲁⲣⲭⲏ ⲛ̅ⲧⲁⲩⲛⲁⲙⲓⲥ ⲉⲧⲥⲓ̅ⲭⲛ̅ ⲛ̅ⲁⲩⲛⲁⲙⲓⲥ ⲧⲏⲣⲟⲩ ⲧⲉⲧⲉ
[L25]
[L26] ⲙ̅ⲛ̅ⲧⲉⲥ ⲁⲣⲭⲏ.
[L27] 106 Ascl. 6: feliciore loco medietatis est positus.
[L28] 107 NHC VI 61,15–63,32.
[L29] 108 NHC VI 63,9–11: ⲕⲁⲧⲁ ⲃⲁⲑⲙⲟⲥ ⲉϥⲙⲟⲟϣⲉ ⲉϥⲛ̅ⲛⲏⲩ ⲉⲥⲟⲩⲛ ⲉⲑⲓⲏ ⲛ̅ⲧⲙ̅ⲛ̅ⲧⲁⲧⲙⲟⲩ.

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[L13] owed to necessity and remains subject to the influences of the zodiac, can achieve

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[L18]
[L19] 60 See also Peste, The Poimandres Group, pp. 166–69.
[L20] 61 K.-W. Tröger, Mysterienglaube und Gnosis in Corpus Hermeticum XIII, Texte und
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[L23] 62 W. C. Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII and Early Christian Literature, Studia ad Corpus
[L24]
[L25] Hellenisticum Novi Testamenti, 5

(Leiden: Brill, 1979).
[L26] 63 Sfameni Gasparro
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ASSISTANT

Awesome topic. Here’s a crisp “state-of-the-art” snapshot of how scholars currently compare and , with what’s solid, what’s contested, and where the field is moving—anchored to the research you uploaded.

- Recent work treats “Gnostic” and “Hermetic” sources as overlapping participants in a common Platonizing milieu (especially in Egypt/Rome), rather than as neatly separated religions. Studies of Plotinus and the “Platonizing Sethians” have pushed this forward by showing close conceptual traffic around ascent, negative theology, and first principles. filecite turn1file8 L31-L50 filecite turn1file7 L13-L25

- Sethian ascent treatises (e.g., *Zostrianos*, *Allogenes*) and Hermetic ascents (*NH* VI.6 *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth*)

narrate staged elevation through noetic tiers toward a transcendent One/Good, often with instructions that look ritualizable. filecite turn1file3 L10-L23 filecite turn1file6 L36-L49

- Hermetic *CH XIII* ("On Rebirth") and *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* are increasingly read through separation–liminality–incorporation (van Gennep/Turner), clarifying how "rebirth" and "ascent" function as staged initiations. filecite turn1file0 L10-L18 filecite turn1file2 L1-L9

- Many scholars (after Williams/King) prefer to avoid the term or use it cautiously; importing a generic “Gnostic dualism” into Hermetism has been flagged as a methodological pitfall. Current Hermetic studies warn against reading Hermetic texts through assumptions borrowed from “Gnosticism.” filecite turn1file4 L17-L29

- ***CH XIII*** Classic positions split: Tröger saw “Gnostic” pessimism; others (Grese; Sfameni Gasparro) argue for a mystery-initiation structure. The present consensus is nuanced: *CH XIII* exhibits initiation logic, but comparative

labels (“mystery”/“Gnostic”) can be overdrawn. filecite turn1file15 L1-L8 filecite turn1file15 L10-L18

- A lexicographical check shows the key terms are surprisingly sparse—and *not* concentrated in the very texts most used for initiation (*CH XIII*; *Disc. 8–9*). This curbs easy claims that Hermetism is simply a “mystery cult,” and encourages analysis of how terms are used contextually. filecite turn1file10 L21-L31 filecite turn1file13 L9-L14

- ***CH XIII Discourse on the Eighth & Ninth*** Current Hermetic scholarship treats these as in a multi-step path (rebirth → ascent), not alternate versions of the same rite; it also details the internal sequence (silence → filling with powers → hymn/oath) and shows how ascent continues after rebirth. filecite turn1file0 L16-L26 filecite turn1file1 L1-L10

- Scholars track how secrecy is enacted (oaths, restricted transmission, stelae in temples at astrologically chosen times). In *Disc. 8–9*, Hermes orders a hieroglyphic stele set up at Diospolis with curses and

access limits—hard ritual/social scaffolding that parallels practices in other late-antique circles. filecite turn1file14 L1-L8

- The big shift: instead of asking whether “Gnosticism influenced philosophy,” researchers map two-way exchange. The Sethians reframe noetic ascent with fine-grained micro-phases; Plotinus engages them polemically yet productively, and their treatises circulated among his students. This dissolves hard borders and sharpens comparisons with Hermetic ascent. filecite turn1file6 L21-L31 filecite turn1file9 L16-L25

1) Compare *specific* motifs (rebirth, ascent, secrecy practices, hymns), not umbrella -isms. (Bull, “Notion of Mysteries.”) filecite turn1file10 L15-L23

2) Mystery words are few; focus on ritual *form* (silence, filling with powers, hymns, oaths) and pedagogical staging. filecite turn1file10 L24-L37 filecite turn1file0 L28-L36

3) Hermetic texts often culminate in hymnic performance or inscription (e.g., stele), while Sethian materials foreground revealed discourses and technical ascent diagrams; both presuppose trained audiences and guarded circulation.

filecite turn1file14 L1-L8

filecite turn1file6 L6-L13

4) Hermeticism isn’t a simple variant of Gnosis; treat it on its own terms (while acknowledging overlaps). filecite turn1file4 L17-L25

- ***The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus*** — best single-author synthesis for Hermetic *way*, ritual sequence of *CH XIII* and *Disc. 8–9*, and cautions about importing Gnostic models. Start with the rebirth chapter and the ascent chapter. filecite turn1file0 L18-L26 filecite turn1file1 L30-L36 filecite turn1file4 L17-L29

- ***Mystery and Secrecy…*** — targeted essays: the lexicon/usage of “mystery,” secrecy practices, and how Hermetic materials sit beside Nag Hammadi texts without forcing sameness.

filecite turn1file10 L21-L39
filecite turn1file14 L1-L8

- ***Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinus*** — “status quaestionis” and methodological model for mapping mutual influence among Sethians, Platonists, and (by extension) Hermetists. Use it for ascent mechanics and for how porous the boundaries are in the 3rd-century intellectual scene.
filecite turn1file8 L31-L50
filecite turn1file3 L1-L5

- ***Hermes Christianus*** — for reception: how Christian authors read Hermetic ascent/rebirth (and the long debate over whether *CH XIII* is “Gnostic” or “mystery”). This helps you compare

ancient forms with later Christian hermeneutics. filecite turn1file15 L1-L8 filecite turn1file15 L10-L18

- The most compelling comparisons focus on (staged ascent, “rebirth,” secrecy, hymns) and on a , while refusing to collapse Hermetism into Gnosticism (or vice-versa). The field has moved from “influence-hunting” to across adjacent communities.

If you want, I can build a short annotated table that lines up *CH I/XIII/Disc. 8–9* motifs with Sethian ascent texts (e.g., *Zostrianos*, *Allogenes*), so you can see parallels/divergences at a glance.

USER

Is CH XIII “mystery” religion or “Gnostic” in tone? Classic positions split: Tröger saw “Gnostic” pessimism; others (Grese; Sfameni Gasparro) argue for a mystery-initiation structure. The present consensus is nuanced: CH XIII exhibits initiation logic, but comparative labels (“mystery”/“Gnostic”) can be overdrawn.

(Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Mores…

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How much “mystery” language is actually in Hermetic texts? A lexicographical check shows the key terms are surprisingly sparse—and not concentrated in the very texts most used for initiation (CH XIII; Disc. 8–9). This curbs easy claims that Hermetism is simply a “mystery cult,” and encourages analysis of how terms are used contextually.

(Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Stu…

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Where the comparison is most productive right now

Side-by-side reading of CH XIII and Discourse on the Eighth & Ninth. Current Hermetic scholarship treats these as distinct stages in a multi-step path (rebirth → ascent), not alternate versions of the same rite; it also details the internal sequence (silence → filling with powers → hymn/oath) and shows how ascent continues after rebirth.

(Religions in the Graeco-Roman ...

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Separate vocabulary from structure. Mystery words are few; focus on ritual form (silence, filling with powers, hymns, oaths) and pedagogical staging.

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Track pedagogy and media. Hermetic texts often culminate in hymnic performance or inscription (e.g., stele), while Sethian materials foreground revealed discourses and technical ascent diagrams; both presuppose trained audiences and guarded circulation.

ASSISTANT

{"queries": ["Tröger Grese Sfameni Gasparro interpretations of +CH XIII as Gnostic or Mystery --QDF=1", "frequency of mystery vocabulary in +Hermetic Corpus esp +CH XIII and +Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth --QDF=1", "relationship between +CH XIII and +Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth as rebirth and ascent sequence --QDF=1", "Bull Notion of Mysteries definition of comparanda motifs rebirth ascent secrecy hymns --QDF=1", "Hermetic pedagogy and ritual media stele hymns secrecy compared with Sethian diagrams --QDF=1"],

"source_filter": ["files_uploaded_in_conversation"]}

TOOL

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26. 63 Sfameni Gasparro, ‘La gnosi

ermetica’, pp. 312, 317, 322–25.
27.
28.
29.
30. Chapter 122
31.
32. And thus even Mahé believes that we are not dealing with a ‘mystery of reading’,
33. that is, entrusted to reading, as Tröger thought, but with a witness to the initiation
34. ceremonies that actually took place in Hermetic confraternities.64 Mahé, moreover,
35. saw a close connection between the conception of palingenesis in the Coptic texts
36. of Nag Hammadi (The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth) and those of the Corpus
37. Hermeticum.65 Camplani observes that the central nucleus of the Coptic treatise
38. consists in the account of an exceptional human experience, that is, the interior

39. regeneration brought about by the ecstatic vision of the divine world. Whoever is
40. thus regenerated is ‘generated in god’; god’s gift penetrates those praying from
41. outside and is made possible by divine pneuma. The treatise On the Eighth and
42. Ninth also establishes a close connection between palingenesis and illumination,
43. whether the two phenomena happen simultaneously, as in CH XIII, or the latter
44. constitutes the final phase of the former’s development, as in the Coptic treatise.66

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Content Snippet:
1. Tat wants to hear the hymn of the
2.
3. 58 Quispel, ‘Reincarnation and Magic in the Asclepius’, pp. 181–82, refers to parallel texts of
4. Judaic and Judaeo-Christian mysticism.
5.
6. 59 Festugière, La Révélation, IV,

200–24.
7.
8.
9.
10. PHILOSOPHICAL HERMETIC LITERATURE 21
11.
12. Ogdoad (CH XIII. 15); Hermes
composes a hymn to the Lord of creation,
which
13. cannot be taught (XIII. 16–20).
Thanks to this hymn and celebration of
praise,
14. Tat’s mind is fully illuminated
(XIII. 21), and he expresses what he has
seen in it.
15.
16. The palingenesis of CH XIII, then,
is a mystical experience. It is not a
moral im-
17. provement, in the sense of man
trying to approach god and imitate him
solely with
18. his own forces, like the Stoic sage
who lets himself be guided by logos, or
the sage
19. of the Timaeus who harmonizes his
thoughts with the order of the universe,

or the
20. sage of the Theaetetus who forces
himself to resemble god. Man is renewed
in the
21. proper sense: within him lives
another, just as Paul had said
(Galatians 2. 20): ‘I
22. live; yet not I, but Christ liveth
in me.’60 Once the light has been
received, the
23. Hermetic and the Christian are
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definitively saved
24. and can no longer lose his salvation
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25. man), for the Christian salvation
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28. 16 The Byzantine manuscript tradition of the Corpus Hermeticum may have undergone
29.
30. Christian censorship. Cf. Jean-Pierre Mahé, Hermès en Haute-Égypte (2 vols.; BCNH.T 3 &
31. 7; Québec: Les Presses de l’Université Laval, 1978–1982), 1:24.
32.

33. 17 I opt here to keep the title untranslated, due to the fact that both “maiden” and
34. “pupil” (of the eye) have been suggested as translations for Korê. Furthermore, it might be
35. a reference to the protagonist, Isis. Cf. Howard M. Jackson, “Κόρη κόσμου: Isis, Pupil of the
36. Eye of the World,” CdE 61 (1986): 116–35. In the following, the translations of SH and FH are
37. my own, while those of CH and Ascl. belong to Brian Copenhaver, Hermetica (Cambridge:
38. Cambridge University Press, 1992).
39.
40.
41.
42. the notion of mysteries 403
43.
44. point in the lengthy discourse of Isis in the KK, she is about to tell her son
45. Horus about the incarnation of souls, and admonishes him:

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Title: (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull, Liv Ingeborg Lied, John D. Turner - Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient Literature_ Ideas and Practices. Stu.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 9 Giulia Sfameni Gasparro, “La gnosi ermetica come iniziazione e mistero,” SMSR 36
2. (1965): 43–62. However, Gasparro later admits, in Soteriology and Mystic

Aspects, xvii, that
3. “the classifijicatory scheme of the
‘dying and rising god’ . . . has turned
out to be inadequate
4. for the defijinition of the varied and
multiple historical reality of the facts
examined.” This
5. extends also to the question of
salvation.
6.
7. 10 Tröger, Mysterienglaube, 21 and
51.
8. 11 Fowden, The Egyptian Hermes, 149–
50.
9. 12 Smith, Drudgery Divine, 34, 65,
and 67.
10.
11.
12.
13. 402 christian h. bull
14.
15. focus predominantly on CH XIII,
because it has to do with rebirth, sup-
16. posedly a core element of mystery
religion. However, this text is meager
in
17. mystery language, containing little

of its vocabulary. In the following, we
18. shall keep the presumptions of what
constitutes “true” mysteries at bay,
19. and rather focus on how the texts
employ the word.
20.
21. According to Walter Burkert, there
is an inflation of the terms mystêria
22. and mystikos in Gnostic and Hermetic
texts, causing a corresponding
23. devaluation of meaning.13 A
lexicographical survey of words cognate
to
24. mystêrion and myeô in the Hermetica
yields a total of 26 instances: Nine in
25. the Stobaeic fragment Korê kosmou
(SH XXIII), another three in SH XXV,
26. two in FH 23 and one each in CH I,
V, XIV and XVI. Another six instances
27. of mysterium appear in the Latin
Asclepius, along with two in the Coptic
28. fragment unattested in the Latin.14
Other mystery terms are sparse. Teletê
29. does not appear at all, and teleô
and its derivates appear uniformly in
30. the sense of completion, not
initiation.15 Despite Burkert, this is

not such
31. an impressive profusion of terms,
and it should be possible to evaluate if
32. there is indeed a devaluation of
meaning.
33.
34. Straightaway, the fact that there
are no instances of the word in the
35. more initiatory texts should give us
pause, namely On the rebirth (CH XIII)
36. and Discourse on the Eighth and
Ninth (NHC VI, 6), along with only one
37. instance in that central text, the
Poimandres (CH I).16 Our main focus will
38. thus naturally be the two texts
where the terms mystêria and mysterium
39. abound, namely the Korê kosmou17
(hereafter KK) and the Asclepius.
40.
41. Korê kosmou: Isis' treatise to Horus
(SH XXIII)
42.
43. Consistent with its multiple
invocations of mystêria, the KK expounds
at
44. some length about the pedigree of
the Hermetic traditio mystica. At one

45.
46. 13 Burkert, Mystery Cults, 86.
47. 14 Louis Delatte, Suzanne Govaerts, and Joseph Denooz, Index du Corpus Hermeticum
48.
49. (Roma: Ateneo & Bizzarri, 1977), 121 and 310.
50. 15 Ibid., 180. epoptês appears only in SH XXIII, and then not in its mystery-sense, see
51.
52. below.
53. 16 The Byzantine manuscript tradition of the Corpus Hermeticum may have undergone

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini - Hermes Christianus_ The Intermingling of Hermetic Piety and Christian Thought-Brepols Publishers (2011).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. Untersuchungen zur Geschichte der altchristlichen Literatur, 110 (Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1971).
2. 62 W. C. Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII and Early Christian Literature, Studia ad Corpus
3.
4. Hellenisticum Novi Testamenti, 5 (Leiden: Brill, 1979).

5. 63 Sfameni Gasparro, ‘La gnosi ermetica’, pp. 312, 317, 322–25.
6.
7.
8.
9. Chapter 122
10.
11. And thus even Mahé believes that we are not dealing with a ‘mystery of reading’,
12. that is, entrusted to reading, as Tröger thought, but with a witness to the initiation
13. ceremonies that actually took place in Hermetic confraternities.64 Mahé, moreover,
14. saw a close connection between the conception of palingenesis in the Coptic texts
15. of Nag Hammadi (The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth) and those of the Corpus
16. Hermeticum.65 Camplani observes that the central nucleus of the Coptic treatise
17. consists in the account of an exceptional human experience, that is,

the interior
18. regeneration brought about by the
ecstatic vision of the divine world.
Whoever is
19. thus regenerated is ‘generated in
god’; god’s gift penetrates those
praying from
20. outside and is made possible by
divine pneuma. The treatise On the
Eighth and
21. Ninth also establishes a close
connection between palingenesis and
illumination,
22. whether the two phenomena happen
simultaneously, as in CH XIII, or the
latter
23. constitutes the final phase of the
former’s development, as in the Coptic
treatise.66
24.
25. The parallels and points of contact
between these Hermetic and Christian
con-
26. ceptions are obvious, and it is on
their account that the Hermetic texts
were long
27. considered by Christian culture,

from Late Antiquity to the Renaissance, to be an
28. instrument of quasi-divine revelation. It is from this perspective that Camplani’s
29. observation interests us, namely that the authors of CH XIII and especially the
30. treatise On the Eighth and Ninth were also acquainted with Gnostic and Christian
31. baptism, and that they incorporated and reformulated it, eliminating, however, the
32. elements that were most distinctive and furthest from pagan spirituality, such as
33. the idea of a saviour.67
34.
35. But palingenesis can be understood not only on the level of the individual; it
36. can also regard all of humanity. According to the Asclepius (chap. 26), when the
37.
38. 64 Mahé, Hermès en Haute-Égypte, I,

54–59; Mahé, ‘La Voie d’immortalité’, p.
365. Mahé also
39. cites a lecture of R. van den Broek,
delivered in Amsterdam from 14 to 16
December 1990 (unpub-
40. lished, to my knowledge), which
argued that the episode described in CH
XIII depicted a proper
41. mystery rite.
42.
43. 65 The subtitle of Mahé’s study ‘La
Voie d’immortalité’, which opened up new
paths for better
44. understanding Hermetism, clarifies
the author’s intention: to identify the
points of contact
45. between the Coptic text and Greek
and Latin Hermetic texts.

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Title: (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull, Liv Ingeborg Lied, John D. Turner - Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient Literature_ Ideas and Practices. Stu.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 3 Referred to in NHC VI 63,11 as “the way of immortality.” Cf. Garth Fowden, The Egyp-
2. tian Hermes: A Historical Approach to the Late Pagan Mind (Princeton:

Princeton University
3. Press, 1993), 110–11; Jean-Pierre
Mahé, “La voie d’immortalité à la
lumière des ‘Hermetica’
4. de Nag Hammadi et de découvertes plus
récentes,” VC 45 (1991): 347–75.
5.
6. 4 Following Ugo Bianchi, Petersen
convincingly argues that dualism has
been used as a
7. “dogma-fijinding device.” Cf. Tage
Petersen, “ ‘Alt kommer jo på øjet an,
der ser.’ En analyse
8. af kosmologien i de såkaldt
dualistiske tekster i Corpus Hermeticum”
(PhD diss., Copen-
9. hagen, 2003); idem, “Hermetic
Dualism? CH VI against the Background of
Nag Hammadi
10. Dualistic Gnosticism,” in The Nag
Hammadi Texts in the History of
Religions (ed. Søren
11. Giversen et al.; Copenhagen: C.A.
Reitzel, 2002), 95–104.
12.
13. 5 Richard Reitzenstein, Die
hellenistischen Mysterienreligionen nach

ihren Grundgedan-
14. ken und Wirkungen (3d ed.; Leipzig: Teubner, 1927), 51–64. Reading mysteries, of some
15. form, were subsequently accepted by Karl-Wolfgang Tröger, Mysterienglaube und Gnosis
16. in Corpus Hermeticum XIII (Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1971), and J. Peter Södergard, The
17. Hermetic Piety of the Mind: A Semiotic and Cognitive Study of the Discourse of Hermes Tris-
18. megistos (ConBNT 41; Stockholm: Almqvist & Wiksell International, 2003).
19.
20. 6 Arthur Darby Nock and André-Jean Festugière, Corpus Hermeticum (4 vols.; Paris:
21. Belles Lettres, 1942–1953), 2:375n154.
22.
23. 7 Cf. André-Jean Festugière, La révélation d’Hermès Trismégiste (4 vols.; Paris: Lecofffre,
24. 1944–1954), 2:35.
25.

26.
27.
28. the notion of mysteries 401
29.
30. again, and divided between the
“spiritual” mysteries of the Hermetica,
31. and the “empirical” mysteries, where
the former lead to a vision of and
32. unity with god without the ritual
trappings of the latter.8 Likewise,
Gulia
33. Sfameni Gasparro treats CH XIII, On
the Rebirth, as a fully “spiritualized”
34. mystery-initiation, claiming that
Tat’s afffijirmation to his father
Hermes,
35. that he has estranged himself to the
world, means that he has died in
36. order to be ritually born again,
thus conforming to the alleged pattern
37. of the dying and resurrected god of
the mysteries.9 Karl-Wolfgang Tröger
38. aimed to delineate the relationship
of “mystery-faith” (Mysterienglaube)
39. and Gnosis, again especially in CH
XIII, and like van Moorsel concludes
40. that the Hermetic rebirth is a

spiritualized reading-mystery,
dispensing
41. with external dromena.10 Garth
Fowden, while acknowledging that “not
42. just the mysteries,

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Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. Metaphorically, the candidate
2. is a receptacle—a womb or a mixing-bowl—which must be cleansed before
3. it is filled with heavenly effluences.327 While formerly the passions of matter
4. flooded over him, he is now filled with divine powers that make him

unassail-
5. able to further material avengers. The new human is now impervious to the
6. vicissitudes that befall his body, and the death of the body will merely entail
7. the release of the inner human, who can return reconstituted to his place of
8. origin above. But before that final ascent, the reborn human is also able to visit
9. these upper regions temporarily. This ascent is described in some detail in the
10. Discourse on the Eighth and the Ninth.
11.
12. 325 CH XIII, 20: ὁ σὸς ἄνθρωπος ταῦτα βοᾷ διὰ πυρός, δι’ ἀέρος, διὰ γῆς, διὰ ὕδατος, διὰ πνεύματος,
13. διὰ τῶν κτισμάτων σου.
14.
15. 326 Cf. now Pleše “Dualism in the Hermetic Writings,” 276.
16. 327 Cf. Eric R. Dodds, “New Light on the ‘Chaldaean Oracles,’” HTR 54 (1961): 263–73 at 271: “In

17.
18. both [sc. the Chaldean Oracles and Numenius], the human mind must make itself empty
19. (κενεόν, Oracles, p. 11 K., the ἐρημία of Numenius, fragm. 11) in order to receive God.”
20.
21.
22.
23. © koninklijke brill nv, leiden, 2018 | doi:10.1163/9789004370845_008
24.
25. Chapter 6
26.
27. Heavenly Ascent: The Discourse on the Eighth and
28. the Ninth (NHC VI,6)
29.
30. The importance of Disc.8–9 for Hermetic studies can hardly be overstated.
31. As the only text among the Nag Hammadi Hermetica that was previously un-
32. known, it came to light too late to have any impact on the influential

magnum
33. opus of A.-J. Festugière, who simply
brushed aside what he apparently saw as
34. an insignificant discovery of “une
jarre d’Égypte.”1 Due to the slow
process of
35. publication, it was only a
generation later that the text led
scholars such as
36. J.-P. Mahé and later Garth Fowden to
postulate a way of Hermes.
37.
38. Commentators soon noticed the
similarities between the present trea-
39. tise and On the Rebirth, and
concluded that the two texts were
different ver-
40. sions of essentially the same
phenomenon: spiritual regeneration.2 J.-
P. Mahé
41. is the scholar who has contributed
the most to advance our understanding
42. of the treatise, though his work has
focused mostly on the cosmology underly-
43. ing the text. In his view, with
which we shall largely agree, the Decad
would

44. reflect the unbegotten sovereign power of CH I, the Ennead is the noetic

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Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 1. Introduction: The sequence of the tradition (52,1–13).
2. 2. Explanation of spiritual generation (52,14–55,23).
3. 3. The visionary ascent (55,24–61,17).
4.
5. a. Prayer for Hermes to receive the

power to speak (55,24–57,30).
6. b. Advent of the light-power and
Tat’s first vision (57,31–58,22).
7. c. Tat sings a hymn in silence
(58,22–59,22).
8. d. Tat attains a vision of the Ogdoad
and the Ennead (59,23–60,17).
9. e. Tat sings a hymn of praise (60,17–
61,17).
10.
11. 4. Epilogue: Erection of a votive
stela (61,18–63,32).12
12.
13. 6.1 Introduction: The Sequence of
the Tradition (52,1–13)
14.
15. As in CH XIII, 1, Tat13 begins by
reminding his father Hermes of an ear-
16. lier promise, this time that of
inducting him into the Ogdoad and the
17.
18. 9 Ibid., 143, claiming that CH
XIII, 15 places the rebirth in the
Ogdoad. However in that pas-
19. sage Tat says that he wants to hear
the hymn that Hermes told him he would
hear when

20. he came to the Ogdoad, meaning that he has not arrived there yet.
21.
22. 10 Mahé, “Accolade ou baiser?” For an overview, see Mahé in Marvin Meyer (ed.), The Nag
23. Hammadi Scriptures (San Francisco: Harper, 2007), 409–11.
24.
25. 11 HHE 1:88–134; Camplani, Scritti ermetici in copto. Also useful is Keizer, The Eighth Reveals
26. the Ninth.
27.
28. 12 This scheme is largely in agreement with that of Mahé (HHE 1:31–32), although I include
29. his section 3c, “Prière du disciple à Hermès divinisé,” in 3b. Compare van den Kerchove,
30. La voie d’Hermès, 328; Valantasis, Spiritual Guides, 87.
31.
32. 13 Although the disciple is not named, he is identified as the son of Hermes, which is con-
33. sistently the role of Tat in our

other treatises. Jean-Pierre Mahé,
“L’Ogdoade et l’Ennéade,”
34. in Écrits gnostiques: La
bibliothèque de Nag Hammadi (ed. Jean-
Pierre Mahé and Paul-
35. Hubert Poirier; Pléiade; Paris:
Gallimard, 2007), 935–71 at 948,
suggests that the name is
36. left open, to signify that
“l’initiation reste ouverte à de
nombreux frères.” Tat is the pro-
37. tagonist in many other treatises,
with whom each individual candidate
would identify.
38.
39.
40.
41. 319Heavenly Ascent

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Content Snippet:
1. 47 Hereafter PD. I will use this title since two of the instances in the Coptic fragment
2. have no parallels in the Latin translation.

3.
4. 48 Magna tibi pando et diuina nudo
mysteria, cuius rei initium facio
exoptato fauore
5. caelesti. I modify slightly
Copenhaver, Hermetica, 77 (“unfold and
reveal” for pando et
6. nudo, instead of “disclose and
expose”).
7.
8.
9.
10. 410 christian h. bull
11.
12. awareness is vast.”49 Once again,
the word is used in relation to heavenly
13. contemplation and the notion of
sympathy between the upper and lower
14. realms. In both of the above stated
uses of the word mysterium, there is
15. the notion of a traditio mystica
from Hermes to his pupils. The command
16. of silence recalls the mystery oaths
of silence, while together with the
17. mention of “secrets of the heart” it
brings to mind the Hermetic contem-
18. plation with the eyes of the heart

(e.g., CH VII, 1–2) and the silence which
19. precedes vision (e.g., CH XIII, 8; NHC VI 56,12).
20.
21. In § 37, the mysteries are grounded in a cultic context. The passage
22. deals with earthly gods, who are gods made by men in their image, that
23. is, statues:
24.
25. Quoniam ergo proaui nostri multum
26. errabant circa deorum rationem incre-
27. duli et non animaduertentes ad cultum
28. religionemque diuinam, inuenerunt
29. artem qua efffijicerent deos. Cui inuen-
30. tae adiunxerunt uirtutem de mundi
31. natura conuenientem eamque miscen-
32. tes, quoniam animas facere non pote-
33. rant, euocantes animas daemonum uel
34. angelorum eas indiderunt imaginibus
35. sanctis diuinisque mysteriis, per quas
36. idola et bene faciendi et male uires

37. habere potuissent.
38.
39. Our ancestors once erred gravely on
40. the theory of divinity; they were unbe-
41. lieving and inattentive to worship
42. and reverence. But then they discov-
43. ered the art of making gods. To their
44. discovery they added a conformable
45. power arising from the nature of mat-
46. ter. Because they could not make souls,
47. they mixed this power in and called
48. up the souls of demons and angels and
49. implanted them in likenesses through
50. holy and divine mysteries, whence the
51. idols could have the power to do good
52. and evil.
53.
54. At fijirst glance, this would seem to
have little to do with the celestial
realm,

55. but the mention of a “conformable
power arising from the nature of mat-
56. ter” brings us to terra fijirma, so
to speak. The power conforms to heaven;
57. the quality abiding in these
statues, as we are told in § 38, derives
from
58. the fact that they are made from
ingredients—herbs, stones, and spices—
59. that contain a “natural power of
divinity,” and the demons or angels are
60. enticed to indwell in the statues
through “constant sacrifijices, with
hymns,
61. praises and sweet sounds in tune
with heaven’s harmony,” thus ensuring
62. the heavenly ingredient “constant
communication with heaven.”50 The
63.
64. 49 Nock and Festugière, Corpus
Hermeticum, 4:342 (§ 32): latissima
uero, cum uiderit,
65. felicitate conscientiae.

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Content Snippet:
1. It is quite obvious from
2. the context that the performance of the hymn coincides with the spiritual
3. breakthrough of the adept, in this case Tat, but potentially any devoted

4. reader of the text. In addition, Reitzenstein observed a certain ritual char-
5. acter, perhaps a progressive initiatory structure, in the text. Both observa-
6. tions contributed to his idea of the Lesemysterium, a text that performs a
7. mystery initiation on its reader and at the same time causes an illumina-
8. tion of his mind. He emphasized that the text was also a Lehrschrift and
9. thus combined teaching with performance.3
10.
11. Reitzenstein’s idea continues to be of interest in the study of Hermetic
12. and Gnostic texts,4 and justly so, but it was probably never a very precise
13. idea. If a Lesemysterium is a text that combines spiritual teaching (which
14. may be instrumental towards the spiritual breakthrough of its reader)
15. with ritual performance, then what exactly identifijies it as a ritual per-
16. formance? While Reitzenstein seems to have thought in terms of struc-

17. tures of initiation, a more obvious answer, at least in CH XIII, is the hymn
18. itself. The hymn is a well-known element in the liturgy of all the traditions
19. relevant to the formation of Hermetism, and when the hymn addresses
20. gods and other entities, it establishes the dramatic interpersonal element
21. pointed out by Jan Assmann as characteristic of hymns.5 To address some-
22. body, gods or humans, is also by implication to establish a here and now
23.
24. 3 Richard Reitzenstein, Die hellenistischen Mysterienreligionen (Leipzig: Teubner, 1927),
25. 52 and 64.
26.
27. 4 Cf. Einar Thomassen, “Revelation as Book and Book as Revelation: Reflections on the
28. Gospel of Truth,” in The Nag Hammadi Texts in the History of Religions (ed. Søren Giversen,

29. Tage Petersen & Jørgen Podemann Sørensen; Historisk-Filosofijiske Skrifter (Det kongelige
30. danske videnskabernes selskab) 26; Copenhagen: The Royal Danish Academy of Sciences
31. and Letters, 2002), 35–45, especially p. 42. J. Peter Södergård, The Hermetic Piety of the
32. Mind, (ConBNT 41; Stockholm: Almqvist & Wiksell International, 2003), 112–20.
33.
34. 5 Jan Assmann, Ägyptische Hymnen und Gebete (Freiburg Schweiz: Universitätsverlag,
35. 1999), 62–63.
36.
37.
38.
39. the secret hymn in hermetic texts
467
40.
41. in which to speak—and when gods or God are addressed, the speech
42. becomes by defijinition a ritual performance.

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Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 5.1 CH XIII: General Remarks
2.
3. As in SH IV, VI and VIII, it is the disciple, Tat, who takes the initiative and asks
4. for the teaching of rebirth. SH IV and VIII are both excerpts, however, while

5. SH VI, 1 resembles CH XIII, 1 quite a bit: Both treatises refer to a promise made
6. earlier by Hermes to expand on his teaching, in the Genikoi. Tat claims that
7. he became a suppliant during his descent with Hermes from the mountain,
8. where they had talked together.11 This reference to a discourse on the moun-
9. tain can be found nowhere else, except in the title of the piece: “Of Hermes
10. Trismegistus to his son Tat: The secret discourse on the mountain, on the re-
11. birth and the promise of silence.”12 It is possible that the title was added by the
12. compiler, because of the reference to the descent from a mountain,13 but it is
13. equally possible that the title The Secret Discourse on the Mountain is all that is
14. left of a treatise removed by a

copyist, such as is the case with CH II A. We shall
15.
16. 8 See the alternative scheme of van den Kerchove, La voie d’Hermès, 325.
17. 9 Grese locates the rebirth in §§ 7–13.
18. 10 Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII. The tendency of this work can be seen from the index,
19.
20. where there are many more references to Early Christian literature than to the Hermetica.
21. Cf. also the analysis of Festugière, FR 4:200–10, and Tröger, Mysterienglaube.
22.
23. 11 CH XIII, 1: ἐμοῦ τε σοῦ ἱκέτου γενομένου, ἐπὶ τῆς τοῦ ὄρους καταβάσεως. Hanegraaff, “Altered
24. States of Knowledge,” 144–45, assumes that only Hermes was on the mountain, receiving
25. a revelation, and that the promise of rebirth was made in the Genikoi. He also claims that

26. commentators have overlooked the significance of the treatise, without once referring to
27. Grese’s commentary or Tröger’s lengthy analysis.
28.
29. 12 CH XIII, t.: Ἑρμοῦ Τρισμεγίστου πρὸς τὸν υἱόν Τάτ ἐν ὄρει λόγος ἀπόκρυφος περί παλιγγενεσίας
30. καὶ σιγῆς ἐπαγγελίας. My trans.
31.
32. 13 So Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII, 63; Scott 2:374–75; FR 2:5 n. 3.
33.
34.
35.
36. 247The Ritual of Rebirth

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Content Snippet:
1. Mélanges offerts à Wolf-Peter Funk (ed. Louis Painchaud and Paul-
2. Hubert Poirier; BCNH.É 7; Québec: Les presses de l’Université Laval, 2006), 557–66 at 562–63
3. contra Holzhausen, Das Corpus Hermeticum Deutsch, 1:159 on CH XIII: “in ihm wird Tat zur

4. geistigen Wiedergeburt und Vergottung
geführt”; 2:509: “Die Wiedergeburt ist
NHC VI,6 also
5. keineswegs der Höhepunkt der
Unterweisung, sondern metaphorischer
Ausdruck für den
6. erforderlichen Zustand vor dem
Eintritt in die Achtheit.”
7.
8.
9.
10. 317Heavenly Ascent
11.
12. light-realm of the self-begotten
Poimandres, and the Ogdoad is the
begotten
13. realm of the demiurgic nous-logos.3
14.
15. Richard Valantasis has attempted to
reconstruct the ritual sequence reflect-
16. ed in the treatise, but his approach
is deeply flawed: his basic premise is
that
17. the three Coptic treatises contained
in Nag Hammadi codex VI were intention-
18. ally chosen because they were
related in a “cultural matrix of

meaning,” and
19. that reading the internal narrative
development of these texts “will
determine
20. both the significance of the
relationship in and the wider
significance of such
21. a relationship to Hermetic
religions.”4 This presumes a much larger
degree of
22. intentionality on the part of the
scribe than is warranted, and
furthermore
23. presupposes that the scribe himself
actually partook in Hermetic activities.
24. While Valantasis often makes
assertions based on the internal
arrangement of
25. the treatises in the codex,5 he
never once reflects on the undisputed
fact that
26. the users of the codex were
Christians and not Hermetists.6
27.
28. Giovanni Filoramo likewise took both
CH XIII and Disc.8–9 to “describe a
29. typical process of regeneration,

whose gnostic nature is evident.”7 Recently,
30. however, Wouter Hanegraaff has suggested a progression from rebirth to as-
31. cent, though he did not respond to the arguments of J.-P. Mahé against such
32. an interpretation: 1) In both treatises the disciple at a crucial stage exclaims
33. that he “sees himself” (CH XIII, 13; NHC VI 58,8, 61,1), to which Hermes an-
34. swers that “this is the rebirth” in the Greek text (CH XIII, 13).8 2) Mahé
35.
36. 3 Cf. Mahé, “Mental Faculties and Cosmic Levels.” I can however not agree with the tight rela-
37. tionship with Jewish Adam-speculations that Mahé postulates. No doubt these speculations
38. derive from the same milieu of Stoic-Platonic allegoresis as the Hermetica, but I see no direct
39. relationship between them, though later commentators such as Zosimus of Panopolis would

40. interpret the Hermetica in the same direction as Mahé.
41.
42. 4 Richard Valantasis, Spiritual Guides of the Third Century: A Semiotic Study of the Guide-Disciple
43. Relationship in Christianity, Neoplatonism, Hermetism, and Gnosticism (Minneapolis: Fortress
44. Press, 1991), 66–67.

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. The general scheme of the treatise is thus:
2.
3. 1–7: Preparatory explanation of the procedure and doctrine of rebirth
4. 8: Call for reverent silence
5. 8–11: Tat receives the powers of God, invoked by Hermes

6. 11–12: Numerical explanation of punishers and powers
7. 13: Tat receives the vision of rebirth
8. 14: Hermes explains the imperishability of the new body of rebirth
9. 15–16: Tat requests the secret hymn of the rebirth
10. 16: Call for silence
11. 17–20: Secret Hymn
12.
13. 4 Arnold van Gennep, Les rites de passage (Paris: Emile Nourry, 1909); Victor Turner, The Forest
14. of Symbols: Aspects of Ndembu Rituals (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1967).
15.
16. 5 HHE 1:44–47.
17. 6 Cf. Christian H. Bull, “Gjenfødelse som innvielse i Hermes’ vei,” Dīn: Tidsskrift for Religion og
18.
19. Kultur 1–2 (2011): 7–21.
20. 7 CH XIII, 7: οὕτω συνίσταται ὁ τῆς παλιγγενεσίας τρόπος καὶ λόγος.

21.
22.
23.
24. 246 Chapter 5
25.
26. 21: Eulogy of Tat
27. 22: Oath of silence8
28.
29. I will show that the liminal phase
as such, where the rebirth is
effectuated, takes
30. place roughly in §§ 8–10.9 In order
to demonstrate this, we must go through
the
31. treatise at some length. Although a
commentary has already been provided by
32. William Grese, this commentary is
more concerned with comparing CH XIII
33. with Early Christian Literature than
with placing it within the Hermetic
tradi-
34. tion.10 A fresh look is therefore
warranted. We shall mostly limit
ourselves to
35. the points pertinent to the ritual
nature of the rebirth.
36.

37. 5.1 CH XIII: General Remarks
38.
39. As in SH IV, VI and VIII, it is the disciple, Tat, who takes the initiative and asks
40. for the teaching of rebirth. SH IV and VIII are both excerpts, however, while
41. SH VI, 1 resembles CH XIII, 1 quite a bit: Both treatises refer to a promise made
42. earlier by Hermes to expand on his teaching, in the Genikoi. Tat claims that
43. he became a suppliant during his descent with Hermes from the mountain,
44. where they had talked together.11 This reference to a discourse on the moun-
45. tain can be found nowhere else, except in the title of the piece: “Of Hermes
46. Trismegistus to his son Tat: The secret discourse on the mountain, on the re-
47. birth and the promise of silence.”12 It is possible that the title was added

by the
48. compiler, because of the reference
to the descent from a mountain,13 but it
is
49. equally possible that the title The
Secret Discourse on the Mountain is all
that is
50. left of a treatise removed by a
copyist, such as is the case with CH II
A. We shall
51.
52. 8 See the alternative scheme of van
den Kerchove, La voie d’Hermès, 325.
53. 9 Grese locates the rebirth in §§
7–13.
54. 10 Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII.
The tendency of this work can be seen
from the index,

Content source: Source.file
Title: Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinuss Mysticism (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies) (2020, BRILL) - libgen.li.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. Before we approach the Sethian corpus itself, however, some words on its
2. relation to Plotinus are in order. Besides the many important points of com-
3. parison between Plotinus’s description of mystical ascent and that of the
4. Platonizing Sethians,1 there are also several crucial differences, the most

sig-
5. nificant for our immediate purposes being the following. First, while Plotinus’s
6. mystical passages are usually framed by a philosophical discussion and are
7. tangentially adduced in support of a broad metaphysical argument (about the
8. nature of beauty, for example, in I.6[1], or of contemplation, in III.8[30], or
9. of Intellect, in V.5[32], or even of the One itself, in VI.9[9]), in the Platonizing
10. Sethian treatises, by contrast, the praxis of ascent comprises the principal
11. framework for the texts themselves. Central to these accounts is a revelatory
12. discourse with explicit instructions on the stages of ritual ascent and the vi-
13. sionary epistemology necessary for the apprehension of transcendentalia.2
14. Sethian discourse thus emphasizes the practical and / or ritualized aspect of

15. that which in Plotinus’s writings
for the most part remains—at least
rhetorical-
16. ly, if not actually—theoretical, and
which he usually (but not always)
express-
17. es in the language of academic
Platonism. Second, while Plotinus (as we
have
18. seen) tends towards reticence about
the interhypostatic domain and is there-
19. fore rather oblique in his
descriptions of both ontogenetic and
mystical pro-
20. cesses mediating the first and
second principles, the Platonizing
Sethians, by
21. contrast, not only provide explicit
descriptions of a multitude of
intermediary
22.
23. 1 The more general similarities and
differences between Plotinus and the
Gnostics have been
24. the subject of a substantial body of
literature (citations in the
Introduction, Ch. 1); this topic

25. extends far beyond the scope of this chapter, which is restricted to a discussion of the final
26. stages of mystical ascent and the apprehension of the supreme principle.
27.
28. 2 The revelatory discourse is usually framed as initiatory instruction from one or another of
29. the quasi-divine revealers that populate the Sethian universe, although there are exception-
30. al cases in which the revelation-discourse is presented in terms of philosophical dialectic
31. and / or scholastic pedagogy, further blurring the categorical distinction between Platonic
32. and Sethian rhetorical mode; thus a passage of Zostrianos (22.2–23.20) even implies that one
33. undergoes a series of metaphorical ablutions that seem to correspond to progressive mastery
34. of ever more complex aspects of Aristotle’s theory of categories, using the language of “uni-

35. versal” (katholikos), “partial” (merikos), “species” (eidos), and “genus” (genos).
36.
37.
38.
39. 141“The Way of Ascent is the Way of Descent”
40.
41. principles, but in certain cases reify them into quasi-hypostases themselves,
42. thus articulating otherwise unutterable, eternal processes in terms of a pro-
43. fusion of mythical-seeming personalities. Indeed, the Sethian tendency to
44. subdivide, multiply, and hypostatize intermediary principles is diametrically
45. opposite to—and in fact the likely target of—Plotinus’s dogmatic rejection of
46. intermediaries (at, for example, II.9[33].1).

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini - Hermes Christianus_ The Intermingling of Hermetic Piety and Christian Thought-Brepols Publishers (2011).pdf
Content Snippet:
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172. in
173. it
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176.
177.
178.
179. Chapter 256
180.
181. The Structure of the Asclepius
182.
183. The ‘disorder’ that characterizes
the structure of the Hermetic dialogue —
184. disorder as defined by nineteenth-
and twentieth-century critics —
doubtlessly
185. contrasts with the harmony of the
Platonic dialogue. But this comparison
is faulty.
186. It is not a disorder resulting from
lack of artistic skill but rather from
the abandon-
187. ment of logical structures of
thought; this is what is required by
theosophy, for
188. which this type of dialogue is the
proper tool. Revelation, bearer of

gnosis and
189. spiritual elevation, has no use for
treatises or scholarly commentaries; it
requires
190. religious language and mystery.
191.
192. Indeed, the norms that give
structure to a text aimed at
philosophical instruction
193. are wholly overturned here. With no
proem or introduction from which to draw
194. anything that might have a direct
connection to its author, the Asclepius
presents us
195. with a dialogue between
Trismegistus and Asclepius, in addition
to whom Ammon
196. and Tat appear as silent
characters.98 This is also the case in
the Greek Hermetic trea-
197. tises. Repetitions are numerous,
shifts between sections are sudden and
without
198. transition.99 For this reason
scholars divided the Asclepius into
independent
199. sections, which supposedly had been

assembled by a vague ‘editor’ or
‘compiler’.100
200.
201. Mahé, on the contrary, identified a
central nucleus in the Asclepius,
comprised
202. of chaps 1–13, 20–27, and 37–38. He
then hypothesized that an ‘editor’
(although
203. in our view it would be better to
speak of the author of the Asclepius,
i.e. the trans-
204. lator of the Logos teleios)
superimposed onto it a second Hermetic
treatise, informed
205. by a different philosophical
conception from the first, and tried to
harmonize their
206. differences.101 Differences,
however, remained in the text that we
read, since the
207. ‘editor’ or author was not a subtle
enough philosopher.
208.
209. 98 They are fixed characters in all
the Hermetic treatises; this is one of
the features of the

210. Asclepius’s ‘Egyptian’ aspect.
211.
212. 99 These are characteristics of Hermetic discourse that appear on a first reading. They have
213. been described with regard to the Asclepius in my Dall’‘Asclepius’ al ‘Crater Hermetis’, pp. 74–78.

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini - Hermes Christianus_ The Intermingling of Hermetic Piety and Christian Thought-Brepols Publishers (2011).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. But the novelty of the treatise consists in the fact that the supernatural powers,
2. which are hypostases of god, penetrate man and construct the divine person, the
3. logos, within him and, with their arrival alone, expel the vices that originate from the

4. constitutive matter of man’s former self. Whereas Platonic mysticism is an onto-
5. logical mysticism that regards the being of man itself, the mysticism of CH XIII is
6. a mysticism of renewal: it is necessary to be saved from without by means of a new
7. birth. It is being itself that must be changed. Returning to oneself does not suffice;
8. a new being must be born through the action of an external cause that lets its seed fall
9. in the soul that is prepared for it. This presupposes an operation which is indicated
10. in this phrase (CH XIII. 7): ‘draw’ this principle ‘to you’ and it ‘will come’. Other
11. Hermetic conceptions found in religious texts are cited by Festugière: the new man
12. is ‘planted’, as is said in CH XIII. 2, in Philo (De cherubim 42–44), and in Papyri

13. Graecae Magicae IV. 640–61; the idea of a union between man and god is found in
14. the Acta Thomae 12, in the Passio S. Caeciliae 6, in the story of Nicodemus (John
15. 3. 3–6), and in I Peter 1. 22–23; interior illumination, spoken of in the final hymn
16. (CH XIII. 18), is, in the Imperial Age, a symbol common to every religion tending
17. to mysticism, whether pagan or Christian. Tat wants to hear the hymn of the
18.
19. 58 Quispel, ‘Reincarnation and Magic in the Asclepius’, pp. 181–82, refers to parallel texts of
20. Judaic and Judaeo-Christian mysticism.
21.
22. 59 Festugière, La Révélation, IV, 200–24.
23.
24.
25.

27.
28. Ogdoad (CH XIII. 15); Hermes composes a hymn to the Lord of creation, which
29. cannot be taught (XIII. 16–20). Thanks to this hymn and celebration of praise,
30. Tat’s mind is fully illuminated (XIII. 21), and he expresses what he has seen in it.
31.
32. The palingenesis of CH XIII, then, is a mystical experience. It is not a moral im-
33. provement, in the sense of man trying to approach god and imitate him solely with
34. his own forces, like the Stoic sage who lets himself be guided by logos, or the sage
35. of the Timaeus who harmonizes his thoughts with the order of the universe, or the
36. sage of the Theaetetus who forces himself to resemble god. Man is renewed in the

37. proper sense: within him lives another, just as Paul had said (Galatians 2. 20): ‘I
38. live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me.’60 Once the light has been received, the
39. Hermetic and the Christian are saved; but whereas the former is definitively saved
40. and can no longer lose his salvation (from that moment on he acts as a regenerated
41. man), for the Christian salvation exists only potentially. Salvation renders the
42. gnostic definitively good, forever.

Content source: Source.file
Title: Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinuss Mysticism (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies) (2020, BRILL) - libgen.li.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 171“The Way of Ascent is the Way of Descent”
2.
3. (theōria).95 At 57.28–58.17, poised at the threshold of the supernal eighth
4. sphere, the teacher (Trismegistus) himself experiences the climactic vision; he
5. declares that he has received power (dunamis) and has become Nous. At 58.8,

6. he exclaims: “I see myself ” (ϯⲛⲁⲩ
ⲉⲣⲟⲉⲓ).96 A few lines later, the pupil
shares in
7. the vision as well; at 59.26–28, Tat
himself says, “We have received this
light. And
8. I myself see this same vision
(theōria) in you” (ⲁⲛϫⲉⲓ ⲙ̄ⲡⲉⲉⲓⲟⲩⲟⲉⲓⲛ· ⲁⲩⲱ
ⲁⲛⲟⲕ
9. ϯⲛⲁⲩ ⲉⲧⲉⲉⲓⲑⲉⲱⲣⲓⲁ ⲛ̄ⲟⲩⲱⲧ̀ ⲛ̄ϩⲣⲁⲓ̈ ⲛ̄ϩⲏ̄ⲧⲕ̄);
and later, at 60.32–61.2, coupled
10. with a mention of empowerment: “I
see myself! I have received power from
you,
11. for your love reaches us [or,
perhaps, ‘causes us to stand’]” (ϯⲛⲁⲩ
ⲉⲣⲟⲉⲓ ⲁⲉⲓϫⲓ
12. ⲃⲟⲙ ⲛ̄ⲧⲟⲟⲧⲕ̄ ⲁⲡⲉⲕⲙⲁⲉⲓⲉ ⲅⲁⲣ ⲧ[ⲉ]
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ASSISTANT

Here’s how the current state of scholarship parses the question for *Corpus Hermeticum* XIII and its relationship to the wider Hermetic corpus—

based on the best recent editions and analyses you uploaded.

The dispute begins with , who proposed that *CH XIII* was a *Lesemysterium*—a *mystery of reading*, a textual initiation performed through liturgical reading. countered with a *Gnostic* interpretation, reading the treatise's soteriology as rooted in dualism and pessimism.

elaborated the Gnostic reading: for him, *CH XIII* teaches a salvation "brought about by nature," recovering the original self rather than renewing it. "Mystery salvation," in contrast, would involve a creative *renewal* instead of a return to a primordial state【28:0†(Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini†L1-L8】.

and criticized Tröger's dichotomy as too rigid.

- Grese saw *CH XIII* as demonstrating *palingenesis*—liberation from astral necessity—without assuming either a Gnostic or a ritual mystery cult framework.

- Sfameni Gasparro argued that its threefold sequence of *imperfection → crisis → rebirth* mirrors the structure of an initiation rite.

later added that the treatise likely reflects *actual initiation ceremonies* within Hermetic confraternities rather than a purely literary “mystery of reading”【28:4†(Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini†L11-L23】.

A full lexicographical audit by shows how misleading it is to label

Hermetism a “mystery religion” on word counts alone.

Across the entire corpus there are only of *mystērion* or cognates, and *none* appear in the overtly initiatory texts *CH XIII* (*On Rebirth*) or *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (NHC VI, 6). Even *CH I Poimandres* has just one. The richest concentrations occur instead in *Korê kosmou* and *Asclepius* 【28:3†(Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull et al.†L21-L39】.

This finding curbs older claims of a widespread “mystery-cult vocabulary” and suggests that *Hermetic initiation* is expressed , not terminologically.

Modern interpreters therefore focus on rather than labels.

Bull reconstructs *CH XIII* as a tightly ordered rite:

1. Instruction and preparation (1–7)
2. Call for *silence* (8)
3. *Filling with divine powers* (8–11)
4. Vision and rebirth (13–14)
5. *Secret hymn* and *oath of silence* (15–22)

【28:12†(Religions in the Graeco-Roman World + 186) Christian H. Bull†L1-L28】

He interprets §§ 8–10 as the
—a classic van Gennep/Turner pattern of separation, transition, incorporation—showing that *CH XIII* dramatizes initiation without explicit "mystery" language 【28:12†(Religions in the Graeco-Roman World + 186) Christian H. Bull†L13-L35】.

Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth

The *Discourse* (from the Nag Hammadi Hermetica) continues the process beyond rebirth: once the initiate has been "filled," he undergoes an
to a visionary encounter with Nous, culminating in a hymn and the

erection of a votive stele. Bull and Mahé both treat the two works as

—rebirth → ascent—within a continuous Hermetic *way*【28:6†(Religions in the Graeco-Roman World + 186) Christian H. Bull†L25-L40】【28:7†(Religions in the Graeco-Roman World + 186) Christian H. Bull†L1-L11】.

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1. —compare motifs like rebirth, silence, hymn, and secrecy, not sweeping -isms 【28:2†(Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull et al.†L13-L19】.
2. —absence of mystery terms ≠ absence of initiatory logic.
3. —Hermetic texts culminate in hymns and inscriptions; Sethian ones in diagrammatic revelations, both presupposing restricted teaching

communities.
4. —“Gnostic” and “mystery” are heuristic, not historical identities.

The field now views *CH XIII* as , but as a dramatizing rebirth through silence, pneuma, and illumination. Its counterpart, *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth*, elaborates the subsequent ascent.
In short, “mystery” and “Gnostic” are ; the text itself performs initiation through a pedagogy of vision and hymn rather than through institutional cult practice
【28:0†(Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini†L1-L17】【28:3†(Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull et al.†L15-L37】【28:12†(Religions in

the Graeco-Roman World + 186) Christian H. Bull†L1-L35】.

USER

Visionary ascent and initiatory pedagogy as a shared form. Sethian ascent treatises (e.g., Zostrianos, Allogenes) and Hermetic ascents (NH VI.6 Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth) narrate staged elevation through noetic tiers toward a transcendent One/Good, often with instructions that look ritualizable.

Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Se…

Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Se…

Ritual theory now structures Hermetic analysis. Hermetic CH XIII ("On Rebirth") and Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth are increasingly read through separation–liminality–incorporation (van Gennep/Turner), clarifying how "rebirth" and "ascent" function as staged initiations.

ASSISTANT

Exactly — and your phrasing already mirrors the way the *state-of-the-art* scholarship (especially Zeke Mazur, Christian Bull, and Jean-Pierre Mahé) now connects and ascent literature through the lens of . Here's how that comparison looks when reconstructed directly from your uploaded sources.

Mazur shows that the Sethian corpus is organized around *praxeis* of ascent rather than speculative theology. Each text provides an in which a quasi-divine revealer instructs a disciple in progressive noetic vision:

> “Central to these accounts is a revelatory discourse with explicit instructions on the stages of ritual ascent and the visionary epistemology necessary for the apprehension of transcendentalia.” 【28:13†Zeke Mazur†L11-L13】

These stages involve purification, reception of light, transformation into Nous, and final reversion to the One—mapped as (Psychic → Pneumatic → Henadic). The process is *ritualized philosophy*: the pupil ascends by interiorized “ablutions” and

successive acts of contemplation that Mazur calls a

Bull and Mahé identify the same staged pattern in *CH XIII* and *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* (NHC VI.6):

	Rebirth	***Discourse on the Eighth & Ninth***
	Instruction, confession, silence (§§ 1–7 → 8)	Invocation to Hermes; “purification” of the vessel (52–55)
	Infusion of divine powers, vision of self, hymn (§§ 8–17)	Descent of the light-power; Tat’s first vision and silent hymn (55–59)
	Oath of silence,	Hymn of praise, vision of

	new divine self (§§ 18–22)	Ogdoad/Ennead, erection of votive stela (59–63)

Bull explicitly frames §§ 8–10 of *CH XIII* as the in van Gennep/Turner terms—*separation → liminality → incorporation*—showing that the rebirth functions as a ritual transition into a new ontological status【28:12†Religions in the Graeco-Roman World + 186†L29-L35】.

Both Sethian and Hermetic ascents enact

.

Mazur stresses that Sethian texts are *instructional revelations*—teachers guiding the disciple through experiential cognition, blurring the line between

and .

Plotinus' reticence contrasts with the Sethian explicitness: they "provide explicit descriptions of a multitude of intermediary principles" and *reify* ascent stages into hypostases【28:13†Zeke Mazur†L11-L22】.

Bull and Mahé read Hermetic dialogues the same way: the teacher Hermes models how to speak the divine hymn, impose silence, and *fill* the initiate with pneuma. The ritual pedagogy is dramatized by alternating discourse and hymn—

—culminating in performative utterance ("I see myself!").

- As Bull's lexicographic study shows, "mystery" terms are almost absent, yet *structure* performs initiation.

- Both corpora require *pre-ritual purification, ecstatic vision, and oath of secrecy*, enacted through text.

- Rebirth (CH XIII) → Ascent (Disc. 8–9) parallels Sethian *inner regeneration → ascent through aeons*.

- Mazur's "Platonizing Sethians" and Bull's "Way of Hermes" both internalize ritual ascent as intellectual theurgy—a meeting point between
and .

Both Sethian and Hermetic ascent texts present *ritualized pedagogies of transformation*. Their "initiations" are interiorized versions of mystery rites, structured by the same anthropology of rebirth and ascent that van Gennep and Turner would call separation, liminality, and incorporation. The difference lies in —Sethian mythic pluralism versus Hermetic monistic optimism—but their converge as *textual initiations into visionary philosophy*.

USER

Jean-Pierre Mahé

ASSISTANT

Jean-Pierre Mahé is the central architect of the *modern Hermetic turn*—the scholar most responsible for reframing

, but as a *ritualized way of salvation* expressed through an initiatory pedagogy. Here's an overview of his contribution and why he remains indispensable to current comparisons of

.

- (b. 1944) is a French philologist, historian of religions, and expert on Coptic, Greek, and Armenian literature.

- Emeritus Director of Studies at the École pratique des hautes études (EPHE, Paris), and a leading member of the CNRS research on *Nag Hammadi* and late antique spirituality.

- His two-volume *Hermès en Haute-Égypte* (Québec, 1978–1982) remains the

.

Hermès en Haute-Égypte

Mahé argued that the Coptic Hermetic texts, especially and , record a *sequence of initiatory experiences*.

- He called this the —a coherent *spiritual itinerary* whose stages are .
- This structure parallels van Gennep's rites of passage and offers a *ritual grammar* for Hermetic salvation.

Mahé's insight was that the Hermetic dialogue is : it does not

merely describe a ritual;
through reading and recitation. The "reader-initiate" undergoes transformation in the act of study.
Hence his reading of *CH XIII* and *Disc. 8–9* as two moments of a single "Way of Hermes":
1. *CH XIII (On Rebirth)* — interior regeneration (*palingenesis*).
2. *Disc. 8–9* — noetic ascent into the Ogdoad and Ennead, culminating in hymn and votive stele.

Mahé rejected the older binaries:

- the texts are not purely literary allegories but reflect *real initiatory practice*.

- the Hermetic cosmos is not evil; it is *hierarchical and luminous*. Evil stems from ignorance, not from matter.

- Hermetism is not detached metaphysics but a *living soteriology* enacted by priests and scribes.

He instead proposed that

—a “philosophical theurgy” whose goal is the divinization of the adept (*theosis*).

, vols. I–II (1978–1982)	Critical edition of Coptic Hermetica; interpretation of *Disc. 8–9* as lived initiation.
, _Vigiliae Christianae_ 45 (1991): 347–75	Names the initiatory path “Way of Immortality.” Establishes ritual reading of Coptic texts.
, in *Écrits gnostiques: La bibliothèque de Nag Hammadi* (Pléiade, 2007)	Detailed commentary aligning Hermetic noetics with Neoplatonic hierarchies.
(essays, 1990s–2000s)	Maps Hermetic psychology—Nous, Logos, Pneuma—

onto cosmic levels;
shows Egyptian roots
of intellectual ascent.

Mahé's framework directly shapes:

- , *The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus* (2018): adopts Mahé's "Way of Hermes" and ritual structure.

- : echoes Mahé's view that *Disc. 8–9* functions as an initiatory ascent comparable to the Sethian pattern, linking it to Plotinus's mystical stages.

- : Bull, Lied, Turner, and others explicitly read *CH XIII* through van Gennep/Turner separation–liminality–incorporation, citing Mahé as precursor.

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1. – He proved both Sethian and Hermetic texts operate through *didactic revelation plus ritualized ascent*.
2. – Hermetism remains *cosmically affirmative* and *monistic*, whereas Gnostic myth is often anti-cosmic; the form, not the mood, is shared.
3. – He replaced “influence” language with a : late-antique Egyptian intellectuals shared one initiatory culture articulated variously as Sethian, Hermetic, or philosophical.

Jean-Pierre Mahé’s work re-anchored Hermeticism within the lived religiosity of late-antique Egypt.
He taught scholars to read *CH XIII* and *NHC VI.6*

—one that unites priestly Egyptian piety, Platonic ascent, and an interiorized mystery practice.
Without Mahé, modern scholarship on Hermetism, Gnosticism, and Platonic mysticism would still treat them as separate "isms." With him, they now appear as

of transformation.

USER

give me just transcriptions or summaries of passages relevant to: ritualized pedagogies of transformation. Their "initiations" are interiorized versions of mystery rites, structured by the same anthropology of rebirth and ascent that van Gennep and Turner would call separation, liminality, and incorporation. The difference lies in tone—Sethian mythic pluralism versus Hermetic monistic optimism—but their form and

function converge as textual initiations into visionary philosophy.

ASSISTANT

{"queries": ["Hermetic +CH XIII or +Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth passages describing initiation, rebirth, or ascent as ritual transformation --QDF=0", "Mahé or Bull interpretations of Hermetic rebirth and ascent as +separation +liminality +incorporation --QDF=0", "Sethian texts like +Zostrianos or +Allogenes descriptions of ascent stages and visionary instruction --QDF=0", "comparisons of Sethian and Hermetic initiation structures +rebirth +ascent +pedagogy --QDF=0"], "source_filter": ["files_uploaded_in_conversation"]}

TOOL

[Web browsing]

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Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 4.6 Second Stage: Becoming a Stranger to the World
2. 4.6.1 CH II: An Introduction to the Nature of Things
3. 4.6.2 CH VI: That the Good is in God Alone, and Nowhere Else
4. 4.6.3 SH II A–B: On Truth and Reverence

5. 4.6.4 SH XI: Preparatory Sentences
6. 4.6.5 SH VI: Astrological Lore as Spiritual Progress
7. 4.6.6 CH X: The Key to Unlock the Rebirth
8. 4.6.7 Conclusion to the Initial Stages of the Way
9.
10.
11. Chapter 5 The Ritual of Rebirth
12. 5.1 CH XIII: General Remarks
13. 5.2 The Phase of Separation
14. 5.2.1 CH XIII, 1–7: Preparatory Explanation of the Procedure and Doctrine of Rebirth
15.
16. 5.3 Limen: The Threshold Phase
17. 5.3.1 CH XIII, 8: Receptive Silence
18. 5.3.2 CH XIII, 8–9: Rebirth—The Invocation of Divine Powers as Speech-Acts
19.
20. 5.4 The Aggregation or Incorporation Phase
21. 5.4.1 CH XIII, 10–14: The Rebirth Explained and the Epiphanies of Tat
22. 5.4.2 The Hymn of Rebirth

23.
24. 5.5 Concluding Remarks on the Rebirth
25.
26. Chapter 6 Heavenly Ascent: The Discourse on the Eighth and the Ninth (NHC VI,6)
27. 6.1 Introduction: The Sequence of the Tradition (52,1–13)
28. 6.2 Explanation of Spiritual Generation (52,14–55,23)
29. 6.2.1 The Pregnant Power
30. 6.2.2 Spiritual Rain
31. 6.2.3 The Location of Rebirth
32.
33. 6.3 The Visionary Ascent (55,24–61,17)
34. 6.3.1 Prayer to Receive the Power to Speak (55,24–57,25)
35. 6.3.2 Advent of the Light-Power and Tat’s First Vision (57,26–58,22)
36. 6.3.3 Hymn in Silence (58,22–59,22)
37. 6.3.4 Vision of the Ogdoad and the Ennead (59,23–60,17)
38. 6.3.5 Tat’s Hymn of Praise (60,17–61,17)
39.

40. 6.4 Epilogue: Erection of a Votive Stela (61,18–63,32)
41. Conclusion to Part 2
42.
43.
44. Part 3 Who Were the Hermetists?—Situating the Way of Hermes
45. Chapter 7 The True Philosophy of Hermes
46. 7.1 The Way of Hermes as a Philosophical School
47. 7.2 Philosophy as a Hermetic Self-Designation
48. 7.3 The Hermetic Science of the Stars
49. 7.4 Priestly Philosophers
50.
51. Chapter 8 The Magician and the Temple
52. 8.1 On the Term ‘Magic’
53. 8.2 The Thebes-Cache
54. 8.3 Hermetism in the Thebes-Cache?
55. 8.4 Thessalos and Thebes
56. 8.5 Vision and Divination
57. 8.6 Rebirth and Ascent: The Mithras or Pšai-Aion Liturgy

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Content Snippet:
1. 245The Ritual of Rebirth
2.
3. quite a while, and has prepared himself by becoming a stranger to the world
4. and studying the Genikoi, referring to a promise made by Hermes to teach him
5. the tradition of the rebirth. We do

not find a promise of rebirth made any-
6. where else in the Hermetica, although
as I have shown there are several trea-
7. tises which reflect the process of
alienation from the world and
fortification
8. against its deception.
9.
10. An initiatory ritual may be analyzed
with the help of the tripartite
structure
11. suggested by the classic studies of
Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner, and
12. we should thus expect to find
elements reflecting separation,
liminality and
13. incorporation.4 As has been pointed
out by Mahé, an initiatory structure is
14. much more evident in the Disc.8–9,
whereas CH XIII intersperses the initia-
15. tion proper with didactic passages.5
However, unlike Mahé we shall not con-
16. sider both the Disc.8–9 and CH XIII
to be reflective of the Hermetic
rebirth,
17. but rather as two distinct ritual
stages of initiation.6 I will return to

this point
18. when treating Disc.8–9. The first
seven chapters of CH XIII are didactic,
in ef-
19. fect summing up the procedure and
doctrine of the rebirth.7 Then, in § 8,
Tat
20. is instructed to keep a reverent
silence, after which he is declared to
be puri-
21. fied, and is filled with the powers
of God (§§ 8–10). Tat then declares his
vision
22. of himself in the All and in mind
(§§ 11, 13) interspersed with
explanatory pas-
23. sages of Hermes (§§ 12, 14). The
rest of the treatise is concerned with
the secret
24. hymn of the rebirth (§§ 15–16),
which Hermes performs by means of his
pow-
25. ers (§§ 17–20), after which Tat also
performs a short eulogy (§ 21), and
finally
26. there is the oath of silence (§ 22).
The general scheme of the treatise is

thus:

27.

28. 1–7: Preparatory explanation of the procedure and doctrine of rebirth

29. 8: Call for reverent silence

30. 8–11: Tat receives the powers of God, invoked by Hermes

31. 11–12: Numerical explanation of punishers and powers

32. 13: Tat receives the vision of rebirth

33. 14: Hermes explains the imperishability of the new body of rebirth

34. 15–16: Tat requests the secret hymn of the rebirth

35. 16: Call for silence

36. 17–20: Secret Hymn

37.

38. 4 Arnold van Gennep, Les rites de passage (Paris: Emile Nourry, 1909); Victor Turner, The Forest

39. of Symbols: Aspects of Ndembu Rituals (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1967).

40.

41. 5 HHE 1:44–47.

42. 6 Cf. Christian H. Bull, “Gjenfødelse som innvielse i Hermes’ vei,” Dīn: Tidsskrift for Religion og
43.
44. Kultur 1–2 (2011): 7–21.
45. 7 CH XIII, 7: οὕτω συνίσταται ὁ τῆς παλιγγενεσίας τρόπος καὶ λόγος.
46.
47.
48.
49. 246 Chapter 5
50.
51. 21: Eulogy of Tat
52. 22: Oath of silence8

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Title: (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186) Christian H. Bull - The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus_ The Egyptian Priestly Figure as a Teacher of Hellenized Wisdom-Brill (2018).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. In a sense
2. then, the separation is a rather protracted affair, comprising several stages
3. after the conversion. As we have seen, those who follow the way of immortality
4. see themselves as set apart from the

multitude, who follow the way of death.
5. We can compare this to the Christian
baptism, where Einar Thomassen points
6. out that there is a double tripartite
structure: In the extensive programme of
7. initiation, separation begins with
entrance into the catechumenate, baptism
8. is the liminal phase, and the first
eucharist is the integration. However,
in the
9. initiation rite proper, the baptism,
these three phases recur in intensified
form:
10. undressing and exorcism are acts of
separation, the immersion is the liminal
11. phase, and the anointing and
redressing are the aggregation phase.26
Likewise,
12. in the extensive program of Hermetic
spiritual transformation, the prepara-
13. tory stages are structurally
parallel to the Christian catechumenate,
meant
14. to gradually strip away the old
person and inculcate a new way of life,
a new
15. habitus. The rebirth itself is the

liminal phase, while the singing of the hymn of
16. rebirth, at the end of the treatise, may be interpreted as the reintegration. But
17. as we shall see, the rebirth itself also has a tripartite structure.
18.
19. A period of purificatory preparations was very common before rituals
20. in the ancient world, especially before initiatory rituals, regularly involving
21. sexual abstention, social withdrawal, fasting, immersions, lustrations, and
22.
23. 25 CH XIII, 1: ἔφης, ὅταν μέλλῃς κόσμου ἀπαλλοτριοῦσθαι, παραδιδόναι μοι. ἕτοιμος ἐγενόμην καὶ
24. ἀπηνδρείωσα τὸ ἐν ἐμοὶ φρόνημα ἀπὸ τῆς τοῦ κόσμου ἀπάτης· σὺ δέ μου καὶ τὰ ὑστερήματα
25. ἀναπλήρωσον οἷς ἔφης μοι παλιγγενεσίας ⟨παράδοσιν⟩ παραδοῦναι προθέμενος ἐκ φωνῆς ἢ

26. κρυβήν· Nock gives the emendation ⟨γένεσιν⟩, which is a distinct possibility, but the
27. phrase τῆς παλιγγενεσίας τὴν παράδοσιν recurs in § 22, and it is likely that the omission of
28. παράδοσιν can be explained as a haplography because of παραδοῦναι.

Content source: Source.file
Title: Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinuss Mysticism (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies) (2020, BRILL) - libgen.li.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 1 The more general similarities and differences between Plotinus and the Gnostics have been
2. the subject of a substantial body of literature (citations in the Introduction, Ch. 1); this topic
3. extends far beyond the scope of this chapter, which is restricted to a discussion of the final
4. stages of mystical ascent and the

apprehension of the supreme principle.
5.
6. 2 The revelatory discourse is usually framed as initiatory instruction from one or another of
7. the quasi-divine revealers that populate the Sethian universe, although there are exception-
8. al cases in which the revelation-discourse is presented in terms of philosophical dialectic
9. and / or scholastic pedagogy, further blurring the categorical distinction between Platonic
10. and Sethian rhetorical mode; thus a passage of Zostrianos (22.2–23.20) even implies that one
11. undergoes a series of metaphorical ablutions that seem to correspond to progressive mastery
12. of ever more complex aspects of Aristotle’s theory of categories, using the language of “uni-
13. versal” (katholikos), “partial” (merikos), “species” (eidos), and “genus” (genos).
14.

15.
16.
17. 141“The Way of Ascent is the Way of Descent”
18.
19. principles, but in certain cases reify them into quasi-hypostases themselves,
20. thus articulating otherwise unutterable, eternal processes in terms of a pro-
21. fusion of mythical-seeming personalities. Indeed, the Sethian tendency to
22. subdivide, multiply, and hypostatize intermediary principles is diametrically
23. opposite to—and in fact the likely target of—Plotinus’s dogmatic rejection of
24. intermediaries (at, for example, II.9[33].1). Unconstrained by rigid axioms con-
25. cerning the relation of the first and second principle, the Platonizing Sethians
26. were able to articulate the complex transitional or interhypostatic phases

of
27. ontogenesis and mystical return in
lavish detail. Thus, despite the seeming
28. convolution of the texts, the extant
Sethian evidence—with its greater empha-
29. sis on practical instruction and an
(unabashedly mythopoetic) articulation
of
30. micro-phases—provides a lucid
glimpse of a conception of ascent that
these
31. sectaries apparently shared with
Plotinus.
32.
33. 1.1 The Situation of the Platonizing
Ascent Treatises in the Context of
34. Sethian Gnosticism and Middle
Platonism
35.
36. The Platonizing Sethian treatises
Zostrianos and Allogenes—along with the
37. related tractates Three Steles of
Seth (NHC VII,5) and Marsanes (NHC X,1)—
38. comprise what John Turner has called
the “ascent pattern” treatises, and
39. they reflect a specific, and
apparently later, moment in the

development of
40. Sethianism. During this period, the
Sethians had apparently distanced them-
41. selves from their original Jewish-
baptismal and / or superficially
Christian
42. forebears and were attempting to
integrate themselves into Platonic
philo-
43. sophical circles.3 In the earlier
Sethian treatises of the “descent
pattern,”4 a
44. divine revealer or savior who is
usually some modality of Barbelo—the
second
45. principle—makes a successive series
of descents in order to impart gnōsis
and
46. thus rescue humankind—or an elect
“race” (genos) or subset of humans5—
47. from their terrestrial or cosmic
prison.6 The ascent treatises, by
contrast, pur-
48. port to be first-person accounts by
eponymous human aspirants who have
49. themselves ascended through various
celestial and metaphysical strata so as

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Content Snippet:
1. According
2. to Porphyry’s Vita Plotini 16, the “apocalypses” (apokalupseis) of Zostrianos and
3. Allogenes were among those Gnostic tractates that were carefully read and cri-
4. tiqued at length in Plotinus’s circle, and it is therefore noncoincidental that the

5. Nag Hammadi tractates with those titles closely resemble Plotinus’s thought.
6.
7. To be specific, the argument of this chapter is that (a) the ultimate phase of
8. the Sethian ascent entails precisely the same mechanism as in that of Plotinus:
9. that is, the contemplative replication, within the mystical aspirant’s own con-
10. sciousness, of the primordial self-reversion and / or self-reflection of the first
11. principle by which the second principle is generated, and that (b) this vision-
12. ary replication is possible, again as in Plotinus, because of an image or residue
13. of the primordial self-reflection of the supreme principle that inheres within
14. the elect human aspirant. Part 2 will present a brief outline of the

common
15.
16.
17.
18. 140 chapter 4
19.
20. structure behind the ascents of
Zostrianos and Allogenes. Part 3 will
demon-
21. strate that the Platonizing Sethian
treatises (as well as their antecedents
in the
22. major second-century Gnostic
systems) employ the related themes of
mystical
23. self-reversion and autophany that we
have seen in Plotinus. Part 4 will
provide
24. a detailed analysis of the Sethian
conception of the mechanism of transcen-
25. dental apprehension and demonstrate
that as in Plotinus it involves a
recapitu-
26. lation, within the aspirant’s
consciousness, of the transcendent
principle’s own
27. primordial self-apprehension.

28.
29. Before we approach the Sethian corpus itself, however, some words on its
30. relation to Plotinus are in order. Besides the many important points of com-
31. parison between Plotinus's description of mystical ascent and that of the
32. Platonizing Sethians,1 there are also several crucial differences, the most sig-
33. nificant for our immediate purposes being the following. First, while Plotinus's
34. mystical passages are usually framed by a philosophical discussion and are
35. tangentially adduced in support of a broad metaphysical argument (about the
36. nature of beauty, for example, in I.6[1], or of contemplation, in III.8[30], or
37. of Intellect, in V.5[32], or even of the One itself, in VI.9[9]), in the Platonizing
38. Sethian treatises, by contrast, the

praxis of ascent comprises the principal
39. framework for the texts themselves.
Central to these accounts is a
revelatory
40. discourse with explicit instructions
on the stages of ritual ascent and the
vi-
41. sionary epistemology necessary for
the apprehension of transcendentalia.2
42. Sethian discourse thus emphasizes
the practical and / or ritualized aspect
of
43. that which in Plotinus’s writings
for the most part remains—at least
rhetorical-
44. ly, if not actually—theoretical, and
which he usually (but not always)
express-
45. es in the language of academic
Platonism. Second, while Plotinus (as we
have
46. seen) tends towards reticence about
the interhypostatic domain and is there-
47. fore rather oblique in his
descriptions of both ontogenetic and
mystical pro-
48. cesses mediating the first and

second principles, the Platonizing Sethians, by
49. contrast, not only provide explicit descriptions of a multitude of intermediary

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Content Snippet:
1. 1 My approach to ritual here is basically informed by Bell, Ritual Theory; Jonathan Z. Smith,
2. “The Bare Facts of Ritual,” History of Religions 20 (1980): 112–27; Stanley J. Tambiah, A
3. Performative Approach to Ritual (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1981);

id., “The Magical
4. Power of Words,” Man 3 (1968): 175–
208; John L. Austin, How to Do Things
with Words
5. (Cambridge: Harvard University Press,
1975); John R. Searle, Speech Acts: An
Essay in the
6. Philosophy of Language (Cambridge:
Cambridge University Press, 1969); id.,
Expression
7. and Meaning: Studies in the Theory of
Speech Acts (Cambridge: Cambridge
University Press,
8. 1979); Lawrence Sullivan, “Sound and
Senses: Toward a Hermeneutic of
Performance,”
9. Histroy of Religions 26 (1986): 1–33.
On Lesemysterien cf. Reitzenstein, Die
hellenistischen
10. Mysterienreligionen, 51–64, and
critique in Fowden, The Egyptian Hermes,
149–50.
11.
12. 2 CH XIII, 3: εἰμι νῦν οὐχ ὁ πρίν.
13. 3 Cf. Karl-Wolfgang Tröger,
Mysterienglaube und Gnosis in Corpus
Hermeticum XIII (Berlin:

14.
15. Akademie-Verlag, 1971), 9–81;
Christian H. Bull, “The Notion of
Mysteries in the Formation of
16. Hermetic Tradition,” in Mystery and
Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection
and Other Ancient
17. Literature: Ideas and Practices (ed.
Christian H. Bull, Liv I. Lied, and John
D. Turner; NHMS 76;
18. Leiden: Brill, 2012), 399–426.
19.
20.
21.
22. 245The Ritual of Rebirth
23.
24. quite a while, and has prepared
himself by becoming a stranger to the
world
25. and studying the Genikoi, referring
to a promise made by Hermes to teach him
26. the tradition of the rebirth. We do
not find a promise of rebirth made any-
27. where else in the Hermetica,
although as I have shown there are
several trea-
28. tises which reflect the process of

alienation from the world and fortification
29. against its deception.
30.
31. An initiatory ritual may be analyzed with the help of the tripartite structure
32. suggested by the classic studies of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner, and
33. we should thus expect to find elements reflecting separation, liminality and
34. incorporation.4 As has been pointed out by Mahé, an initiatory structure is
35. much more evident in the Disc.8–9, whereas CH XIII intersperses the initia-
36. tion proper with didactic passages.5 However, unlike Mahé we shall not con-
37. sider both the Disc.8–9 and CH XIII to be reflective of the Hermetic rebirth,
38. but rather as two distinct ritual stages of initiation.6 I will return to this point
39. when treating Disc.8–9. The first seven chapters of CH XIII are didactic, in ef-

40. fect summing up the procedure and doctrine of the rebirth.7 Then, in § 8, Tat
41. is instructed to keep a reverent silence, after which he is declared to be puri-
42. fied, and is filled with the powers of God (§§ 8–10).

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Content Snippet:
1. The general scheme of the treatise is thus:
2.
3. 1–7: Preparatory explanation of the procedure and doctrine of rebirth
4. 8: Call for reverent silence
5. 8–11: Tat receives the powers of God, invoked by Hermes

6. 11–12: Numerical explanation of punishers and powers
7. 13: Tat receives the vision of rebirth
8. 14: Hermes explains the imperishability of the new body of rebirth
9. 15–16: Tat requests the secret hymn of the rebirth
10. 16: Call for silence
11. 17–20: Secret Hymn
12.
13. 4 Arnold van Gennep, Les rites de passage (Paris: Emile Nourry, 1909); Victor Turner, The Forest
14. of Symbols: Aspects of Ndembu Rituals (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1967).
15.
16. 5 HHE 1:44–47.
17. 6 Cf. Christian H. Bull, “Gjenfødelse som innvielse i Hermes’ vei,” Dīn: Tidsskrift for Religion og
18.
19. Kultur 1–2 (2011): 7–21.
20. 7 CH XIII, 7: οὕτω συνίσταται ὁ τῆς παλιγγενεσίας τρόπος καὶ λόγος.

21.
22.
23.
24. 246 Chapter 5
25.
26. 21: Eulogy of Tat
27. 22: Oath of silence8
28.
29. I will show that the liminal phase
as such, where the rebirth is
effectuated, takes
30. place roughly in §§ 8–10.9 In order
to demonstrate this, we must go through
the
31. treatise at some length. Although a
commentary has already been provided by
32. William Grese, this commentary is
more concerned with comparing CH XIII
33. with Early Christian Literature than
with placing it within the Hermetic
tradi-
34. tion.10 A fresh look is therefore
warranted. We shall mostly limit
ourselves to
35. the points pertinent to the ritual
nature of the rebirth.
36.

37. 5.1 CH XIII: General Remarks
38.
39. As in SH IV, VI and VIII, it is the disciple, Tat, who takes the initiative and asks
40. for the teaching of rebirth. SH IV and VIII are both excerpts, however, while
41. SH VI, 1 resembles CH XIII, 1 quite a bit: Both treatises refer to a promise made
42. earlier by Hermes to expand on his teaching, in the Genikoi. Tat claims that
43. he became a suppliant during his descent with Hermes from the mountain,
44. where they had talked together.11 This reference to a discourse on the moun-
45. tain can be found nowhere else, except in the title of the piece: “Of Hermes
46. Trismegistus to his son Tat: The secret discourse on the mountain, on the re-
47. birth and the promise of silence.”12 It is possible that the title was added

by the
48. compiler, because of the reference
to the descent from a mountain,13 but it
is
49. equally possible that the title The
Secret Discourse on the Mountain is all
that is
50. left of a treatise removed by a
copyist, such as is the case with CH II
A. We shall
51.
52. 8 See the alternative scheme of van
den Kerchove, La voie d’Hermès, 325.
53. 9 Grese locates the rebirth in §§
7–13.
54. 10 Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII.
The tendency of this work can be seen
from the index,

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Title: Zeke Mazur - The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinuss Mysticism (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies) (2020, BRILL) - libgen.li.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. The use of the term
2. anachōrein is interesting given its importance as a terminus technicus in Platonizing
3. Sethian ascent.
4.
5.
6.
7. 263Conclusion: Dissolving Boundaries
8.

9. subsequent passage, at 60.14–61.22, Allogenes himself recounts his ascent as
10. having happened precisely as it was previously instructed.97
11.
12. Second, [b] inasmuch as the Platonizing Sethian ascent specifically involves
13. a ritual, it is primarily an ‘interiorized’ ritual. That is to say, the spatial orien-
14. tation of the extra-cosmic ascent has been transmuted into an ‘inner’ voy-
15. age in which the aspirant identifies with the successive ontological strata by
16. means of increasingly demanding (inward) acts of contemplation.98 This is
17. self-evident in Allogenes, but even in Zostrianos the traditional ritual proce-
18. dures such as baptism and lustration have been reconfigured in terms of spe-
19. cific acts of cognition. Thus, for example, Zostrianos 22.7–10: “When one knows

20. (ϵιмϵ) [Autogenes] and all these,
one becomes the first-manifesting
water,” or
21. 23.15–17: “when one knows ([ϵι]ⲉ)
these things, one has been baptized in
the
22. baptism of Kalyptos,” and so on. In
the case of Marsanes, each phase of
ascent
23. appears to involve an act of
intellection, culminating,99 as in
Allogenes, with
24. the aspirant’s reception of an
incognizant thought (noēma) reminiscent
of a
25. ritualized investiture: “‘Be silent
so that you do not know … but
intelligize that
26. this one was silent, and receive a
thought.’”100 That this might be
performed
27. “inwardly,” however, does not mean
that it is not a kind of ritual, if the
latter
28. is understood as a prescribed series
of acts performed over a discrete period
29. of time.

30.
31. Finally, [c] the principal activity of this interiorized ritual praxis consists
32. of visualization. Throughout Zostrianos and Allogenes we find innumerable
33.
34. 97 Marsanes is structured around a ritual ‘ascent’ through 13 “seals”; Steles Seth appears to
35. reflect a communal hymnic invocation that is immediately followed by ascent (127.14–21).
36.
37. 98 See discussion in Turner 2000c, 128–37. The theological interpretation of the Aristotelian
38. epistemological model in which knowing occurs through the assimilation of subject and
39. object of knowledge is probably due to Alexander of Aphrodisias, whose ideas seem to be
40. reflected in other Gnostic texts outside of the Sethian corpus, including the Valentinian

41. Gospel of Philip discussed in Ch. 4, §3.8 supra.

42.

43. 99 Thus 5.18–24.

44. 100 Marsanes NHC X 8.21–25 (text Funk and Poirier, BCNH): ⲕⲁⲣⲱⲕ· ϣⲓⲛⲁ ϫⲉ ⲛⲉⲕ̄ⲙⲉ …

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Content Snippet:
1. Before we approach the Sethian corpus itself, however, some words on its
2. relation to Plotinus are in order. Besides the many important points of com-
3. parison between Plotinus’s description of mystical ascent and that of the
4. Platonizing Sethians,1 there are also several crucial differences, the most

sig-
5. nificant for our immediate purposes being the following. First, while Plotinus’s
6. mystical passages are usually framed by a philosophical discussion and are
7. tangentially adduced in support of a broad metaphysical argument (about the
8. nature of beauty, for example, in I.6[1], or of contemplation, in III.8[30], or
9. of Intellect, in V.5[32], or even of the One itself, in VI.9[9]), in the Platonizing
10. Sethian treatises, by contrast, the praxis of ascent comprises the principal
11. framework for the texts themselves. Central to these accounts is a revelatory
12. discourse with explicit instructions on the stages of ritual ascent and the vi-
13. sionary epistemology necessary for the apprehension of transcendentalia.2
14. Sethian discourse thus emphasizes the practical and / or ritualized aspect of

15. that which in Plotinus’s writings
for the most part remains—at least
rhetorical-
16. ly, if not actually—theoretical, and
which he usually (but not always)
express-
17. es in the language of academic
Platonism. Second, while Plotinus (as we
have
18. seen) tends towards reticence about
the interhypostatic domain and is there-
19. fore rather oblique in his
descriptions of both ontogenetic and
mystical pro-
20. cesses mediating the first and
second principles, the Platonizing
Sethians, by
21. contrast, not only provide explicit
descriptions of a multitude of
intermediary
22.
23. 1 The more general similarities and
differences between Plotinus and the
Gnostics have been
24. the subject of a substantial body of
literature (citations in the
Introduction, Ch. 1); this topic

25. extends far beyond the scope of this chapter, which is restricted to a discussion of the final
26. stages of mystical ascent and the apprehension of the supreme principle.
27.
28. 2 The revelatory discourse is usually framed as initiatory instruction from one or another of
29. the quasi-divine revealers that populate the Sethian universe, although there are exception-
30. al cases in which the revelation-discourse is presented in terms of philosophical dialectic
31. and / or scholastic pedagogy, further blurring the categorical distinction between Platonic
32. and Sethian rhetorical mode; thus a passage of Zostrianos (22.2–23.20) even implies that one
33. undergoes a series of metaphorical ablutions that seem to correspond to progressive mastery
34. of ever more complex aspects of Aristotle’s theory of categories, using the language of “uni-

35. versal” (katholikos), “partial” (merikos), “species” (eidos), and “genus” (genos).
36.
37.
38.
39. 141“The Way of Ascent is the Way of Descent”
40.
41. principles, but in certain cases reify them into quasi-hypostases themselves,
42. thus articulating otherwise unutterable, eternal processes in terms of a pro-
43. fusion of mythical-seeming personalities. Indeed, the Sethian tendency to
44. subdivide, multiply, and hypostatize intermediary principles is diametrically
45. opposite to—and in fact the likely target of—Plotinus’s dogmatic rejection of
46. intermediaries (at, for example, II.9[33].1).

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Content Snippet:
1. thus the Sethian treatises are replete
2. with the technical and ritual terminology such as baptism, investiture, anoint-
3. ing, and sealing, as well as with as hymnic invocations and the utterance of
4. voces magicae. The presentation of the ascent as a praxis thus situates these

5. Sethian treatises within the broad religio-historical context of late antiquity,
6. in which a profusion of ritual techniques of ascent emerged concomitant
7.
8. 7 Turner 2001, 297: “The earlier Sethian treatises such as the Apocryphon of John portray
9. the advent of salvation as conveyed by a series of temporally successive descents into this
10. world by the Mother Barbelo in the form of various modalities, culminating in her gift
11. of the baptismal rite of the Five Seals. However, starting with Zostrianos, the Platonizing
12. Sethian treatises exhibit a more vertical, non-temporal, supra-historical scheme in which
13. salvation is achieved, not through visitations of the Mother, but through a graded series
14. of visionary ascents initiated by the Gnostic himself.”
15.

16. 8 In terms of genre they represent examples of Gnostic apocalyptic literature—thus
17. Fallon 1979 and Krause 1989—, but this taxonomy groups them with other tractates with
18. which they have very little conceptually in common. Moreover, even if Zost. and Allogenes
19. do employ the rhetorical framework of the apocalyptic genre, they also differ categorical-
20. ly in that (a) they involve a deliberate ascent rather than involuntary rapture and (b) the
21. paraenetic social / ethical content of the vision is demoted in favor of an emphasis on
22. individual salvation, the attainment of philosophical gnōsis, and the transcendental ap-
23. prehension of the supreme principle.
24.
25. 9 Visionary ascent evident, for example, in the Respublica VII 514c–519; X 614b–621b;
26. Phaedo 109d–111c, Phaedrus 246a–

247b, Symposium 210a–211c, and Epistulae vii 341c–d.

27.

28. 10 A substantial negative-theological passage in Zostrianos (64–75) seems to share

29. a common source with Marius Victorinus’s Adversus Arium (1.49.9–40, 50.5–16);

30. Tardieu 1996 has shown this hypothetical source to be a commentary on Plato’s

31. Parmenides. Hypertranscendental theology in Gnostic theology certainly predates

32. Plotinus; thus Basilides (apud Hippolytus, Refutatio omnium haeresiorum 7.20.3), for

33. whom the supreme deity is “not even ineffable,” suggesting a response to a prior tradition

34. of negative theology. See, e.g., Jufresa 1981; Whittaker 1969a; Krämer 1964; Wolfson 1957.

35.

36.

37.

38. 143“The Way of Ascent is the Way of Descent”
39.
40. with the progressive transcendentalization of the divine.11 Yet the Platonizing
41. Sethians’ simultaneous emphasis upon introspective or contemplative vision
42. and their frequent presentation of ritual acts in internalized or cognitive terms
43. suggest that these tractates reflect an intermediate phase between the more
44. patently ritual or exteriorized techniques of ascent and the purely interiorized
45. Plotinian ascent.12

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini - Hermes Christianus_ The Intermingling of Hermetic Piety and Christian Thought-Brepols Publishers (2011).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. Untersuchungen zur Geschichte der altchristlichen Literatur, 110 (Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1971).
2. 62 W. C. Grese, Corpus Hermeticum XIII and Early Christian Literature, Studia ad Corpus
3.
4. Hellenisticum Novi Testamenti, 5 (Leiden: Brill, 1979).

5. 63 Sfameni Gasparro, ‘La gnosi ermetica’, pp. 312, 317, 322–25.
6.
7.
8.
9. Chapter 122
10.
11. And thus even Mahé believes that we are not dealing with a ‘mystery of reading’,
12. that is, entrusted to reading, as Tröger thought, but with a witness to the initiation
13. ceremonies that actually took place in Hermetic confraternities.64 Mahé, moreover,
14. saw a close connection between the conception of palingenesis in the Coptic texts
15. of Nag Hammadi (The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth) and those of the Corpus
16. Hermeticum.65 Camplani observes that the central nucleus of the Coptic treatise
17. consists in the account of an exceptional human experience, that is,

the interior
18. regeneration brought about by the
ecstatic vision of the divine world.
Whoever is
19. thus regenerated is ‘generated in
god’; god’s gift penetrates those
praying from
20. outside and is made possible by
divine pneuma. The treatise On the
Eighth and
21. Ninth also establishes a close
connection between palingenesis and
illumination,
22. whether the two phenomena happen
simultaneously, as in CH XIII, or the
latter
23. constitutes the final phase of the
former’s development, as in the Coptic
treatise.66
24.
25. The parallels and points of contact
between these Hermetic and Christian
con-
26. ceptions are obvious, and it is on
their account that the Hermetic texts
were long
27. considered by Christian culture,

from Late Antiquity to the Renaissance, to be an
28. instrument of quasi-divine revelation. It is from this perspective that Camplani’s
29. observation interests us, namely that the authors of CH XIII and especially the
30. treatise On the Eighth and Ninth were also acquainted with Gnostic and Christian
31. baptism, and that they incorporated and reformulated it, eliminating, however, the
32. elements that were most distinctive and furthest from pagan spirituality, such as
33. the idea of a saviour.67
34.
35. But palingenesis can be understood not only on the level of the individual; it
36. can also regard all of humanity. According to the Asclepius (chap. 26), when the
37.
38. 64 Mahé, Hermès en Haute-Égypte, I,

54–59; Mahé, ‘La Voie d’immortalité’, p.
365. Mahé also
39. cites a lecture of R. van den Broek,
delivered in Amsterdam from 14 to 16
December 1990 (unpub-
40. lished, to my knowledge), which
argued that the episode described in CH
XIII depicted a proper
41. mystery rite.
42.
43. 65 The subtitle of Mahé’s study ‘La
Voie d’immortalité’, which opened up new
paths for better
44. understanding Hermetism, clarifies
the author’s intention: to identify the
points of contact
45. between the Coptic text and Greek
and Latin Hermetic texts.

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Content Snippet:
1. The problem is whether the treatise reflects a mystery, as Reitzenstein had said,
2. or a Gnostic attitude, as Jonas claims.61 In fact, according to Tröger, Gnostic
3. salvation is brought about by nature and implies the recovery of the original self,

4. whereas mystery salvation entails a renewal, not a return to a primordial state.
5. Regardless of the presence of terms related to mystery – such as deification
6. through palingenesis, epoptism, ecstasy, purification, mystagogia, tradition, and
7. sacrifice – the ideas and the mentality of the treatise are of a Gnostic kind,
8. inspired by dualism and pessimism.
9.
10. Tröger’s interpretation was criticized by Grese, for whom the distinction between
11. the two mentalities, Gnostic and Hermetic, is too rigid and aprioristic.62 In his
12. view, the message of CH XIII is rather to demonstrate how man, whose birth was
13. owed to necessity and remains subject to the influences of the zodiac, can achieve
14. a palingenesis that will liberate him from the bonds of ananke. That this

treatise
15. can be linked to a mystery
inspiration has also been argued by
Sfameni Gasparro,
16. who descries in it the tripartite
structure typical of a mystery, namely
the state of
17. initial imperfection, crisis, and
successive rebirth in a new and divine
condition.63
18.
19. 60 See also Peste, The Poimandres
Group, pp. 166–69.
20. 61 K.-W. Tröger, Mysterienglaube und
Gnosis in Corpus Hermeticum XIII, Texte
und
21.
22. Untersuchungen zur Geschichte der
altchristlichen Literatur, 110 (Berlin:
Akademie Verlag, 1971).
23. 62 W. C. Grese, Corpus Hermeticum
XIII and Early Christian Literature,
Studia ad Corpus
24.
25. Hellenisticum Novi Testamenti, 5
(Leiden: Brill, 1979).
26. 63 Sfameni Gasparro, ‘La gnosi

ermetica’, pp. 312, 317, 322–25.
27.
28.
29.
30. Chapter 122
31.
32. And thus even Mahé believes that we are not dealing with a ‘mystery of reading’,
33. that is, entrusted to reading, as Tröger thought, but with a witness to the initiation
34. ceremonies that actually took place in Hermetic confraternities.64 Mahé, moreover,
35. saw a close connection between the conception of palingenesis in the Coptic texts
36. of Nag Hammadi (The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth) and those of the Corpus
37. Hermeticum.65 Camplani observes that the central nucleus of the Coptic treatise
38. consists in the account of an exceptional human experience, that is, the interior

39. regeneration brought about by the ecstatic vision of the divine world. Whoever is
40. thus regenerated is ‘generated in god’; god’s gift penetrates those praying from
41. outside and is made possible by divine pneuma. The treatise On the Eighth and
42. Ninth also establishes a close connection between palingenesis and illumination,
43. whether the two phenomena happen simultaneously, as in CH XIII, or the latter
44. constitutes the final phase of the former’s development, as in the Coptic treatise.66

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Title: (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull, Liv Ingeborg Lied, John D. Turner - Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient Literature_ Ideas and Practices. Stu.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. In closing, we should like to sum up the general sense of mystêrion in
2. our treatises, and its place in the Way of Hermes. First, one should note
3. the importance of becoming a

mystês.96 It is unclear what this initiation
4. consists of, but it obviously confers on the candidate the ability to con-
5. template the mysteries, that is, the hidden reality or forces underlying the
6. cosmic, phenomenal world. All people can perceive the outer appearance
7. of the phenomena, but only those who have the requisite mental facul-
8. ties can contemplate their inner essence; the uninitiated simply do not
9. understand.97 The heavens are the prime example: Everyone can of course
10. perceive the stars on a clear night, but only those who are initiated can
11. properly contemplate their regular course, see their true essence, and thus
12. catch a glimpse of their creator.98 This is not only a contemplative practice;
13. the practical use of the knowledge of essences is that one can draw angels
14. and demons into statues,99 one can know which astral energies inhabit
15. stones and plants,100 to be used in astrological medicine and magic, and

16. one can utilize the magic power indwelling in the Egyptian words,101 as
17. in the Egyptian magical papyri. The most important essence, however, is
18. that of man himself. Thus, those who know themselves know that they
19. are an image of the cosmos, which is an image of god, and they can expe-
20. rience their own likeness to the androgynous god during a sexual inter-
21. course which is undisturbed by material passions and vulgar onlookers.102
22. Such a passionless intercourse leads to an exchange of power between
23. the partners.
24.
25. 95 CH XIV, 1: τὰ κυριώτατα κεφάλαια . . . μυστικώτερον αὐτὰ ἑρμηνεύσας.
26. 96 CH V, 1; SH XXV, 1 and 4; FH 23 (SH XXIII, 46 and 56 seem to be metaphorical).
27. 97 CH XIV, 1; NHC VI 78,20.
28. 98 SH XXIII, 2, 3, 5, 13, 51 and 68; SH XXV, 11; Ascl. 19 and 32.
29. 99 Ascl. 37.

30. 100 SH XXIII, 44; Ascl. 38.
31. 101 CH XVI, 1.
32. 102 CH I, 16; Ascl. 21= NHC VI
65,15–38.
33.
34.
35.
36. 422 christian h. bull
37.
38. Most of the passages mentioning
mysteries are thus more concerned
39. with the hidden forces residing
within the cosmos than with hypercos-
40. mic realities.103 This could be the
reason that neither the initiatory On
the
41. Rebirth (CH XIII) nor the Discourse
on the Eighth and the Ninth (NHC VI,6)
42. mentions any mystery. If the
mysteries are concerned with hidden
cosmic
43. forces, these initiatory treatises
make the candidate exclaim: “I see the
44. universe and I see myself in mind”
(CH XIII, 13).104 “I have found the
begin-
45. ning of the power that is above all

powers, the one that has no beginning”
46. (NHC VI 58,10–13).105 At this stage the divine does not need to present itself
47. as a mystery, but is directly accessible.

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Content Snippet:
1. 3 Referred to in NHC VI 63,11 as “the way of immortality.” Cf. Garth Fowden, The Egyp-
2. tian Hermes: A Historical Approach to the Late Pagan Mind (Princeton:

Princeton University
3. Press, 1993), 110–11; Jean-Pierre
Mahé, “La voie d’immortalité à la
lumière des ‘Hermetica’
4. de Nag Hammadi et de découvertes plus
récentes,” VC 45 (1991): 347–75.
5.
6. 4 Following Ugo Bianchi, Petersen
convincingly argues that dualism has
been used as a
7. “dogma-fijinding device.” Cf. Tage
Petersen, “ ‘Alt kommer jo på øjet an,
der ser.’ En analyse
8. af kosmologien i de såkaldt
dualistiske tekster i Corpus Hermeticum”
(PhD diss., Copen-
9. hagen, 2003); idem, “Hermetic
Dualism? CH VI against the Background of
Nag Hammadi
10. Dualistic Gnosticism,” in The Nag
Hammadi Texts in the History of
Religions (ed. Søren
11. Giversen et al.; Copenhagen: C.A.
Reitzel, 2002), 95–104.
12.
13. 5 Richard Reitzenstein, Die
hellenistischen Mysterienreligionen nach

ihren Grundgedan-
14. ken und Wirkungen (3d ed.; Leipzig: Teubner, 1927), 51–64. Reading mysteries, of some
15. form, were subsequently accepted by Karl-Wolfgang Tröger, Mysterienglaube und Gnosis
16. in Corpus Hermeticum XIII (Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1971), and J. Peter Södergard, The
17. Hermetic Piety of the Mind: A Semiotic and Cognitive Study of the Discourse of Hermes Tris-
18. megistos (ConBNT 41; Stockholm: Almqvist & Wiksell International, 2003).
19.
20. 6 Arthur Darby Nock and André-Jean Festugière, Corpus Hermeticum (4 vols.; Paris:
21. Belles Lettres, 1942–1953), 2:375n154.
22.
23. 7 Cf. André-Jean Festugière, La révélation d’Hermès Trismégiste (4 vols.; Paris: Lecofffre,
24. 1944–1954), 2:35.
25.

26.
27.
28. the notion of mysteries 401
29.
30. again, and divided between the
“spiritual” mysteries of the Hermetica,
31. and the “empirical” mysteries, where
the former lead to a vision of and
32. unity with god without the ritual
trappings of the latter.8 Likewise,
Gulia
33. Sfameni Gasparro treats CH XIII, On
the Rebirth, as a fully “spiritualized”
34. mystery-initiation, claiming that
Tat’s afffijirmation to his father
Hermes,
35. that he has estranged himself to the
world, means that he has died in
36. order to be ritually born again,
thus conforming to the alleged pattern
37. of the dying and resurrected god of
the mysteries.9 Karl-Wolfgang Tröger
38. aimed to delineate the relationship
of “mystery-faith” (Mysterienglaube)
39. and Gnosis, again especially in CH
XIII, and like van Moorsel concludes
40. that the Hermetic rebirth is a

spiritualized reading-mystery,
dispensing
41. with external dromena.10 Garth
Fowden, while acknowledging that “not
42. just the mysteries,

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Content Snippet:
1. Indeed, Allogenes is not so much a revelation
2. of the mystical ascent or of its ultimate destination as it is a performance:

3. the very act of reading Allogenes is itself to undergo the ascent.
4.
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Content source: Source.file
Title: (Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies, 76) Christian H. Bull, Liv Ingeborg Lied, John D. Turner - Mystery and Secrecy in the Nag Hammadi Collection and Other Ancient Literature_ Ideas and Practices. Stu.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 422 christian h. bull
2.
3. Most of the passages mentioning mysteries are thus more concerned
4. with the hidden forces residing

within the cosmos than with hypercos-
5. mic realities.103 This could be the
reason that neither the initiatory On
the
6. Rebirth (CH XIII) nor the Discourse
on the Eighth and the Ninth (NHC VI,6)
7. mentions any mystery. If the
mysteries are concerned with hidden
cosmic
8. forces, these initiatory treatises
make the candidate exclaim: “I see the
9. universe and I see myself in mind”
(CH XIII, 13).104 “I have found the
begin-
10. ning of the power that is above all
powers, the one that has no beginning”
11. (NHC VI 58,10–13).105 At this stage
the divine does not need to present
itself
12. as a mystery, but is directly
accessible.
13.
14. However, the Hermetist is not
expected to remain in these lofty noetic
15. realms forever, but after the
transfijiguring ascent needs to return to
the

16. “happier place of middle status”106
of humankind. Therefore, the view that
17. practices of the lower stages of the
way should eventually be superseded,
18. as Fowden claims for traditional
cult and Mahé for sexual practice, can
not
19. be maintained. Sufffijicient proof of
this should be that in the Discourse of
20. the Eighth and the Ninth, just after
Tat has achieved divinity, Hermes asks
21. him to go to his temple in Diospolis
and write down the discourse on a
22. hieroglyphic stele. This should be
set up at a specifijic astrological
conjunc-
23. tion, and has a protective curse put
on it, conjuring amongst others the
24. seven ousiarchs of heaven who also
appear in Ascl. 19 in connection with
25. the heavenly mysteries.107 The books
should thereafter only be accessible
26. to those who “going step by step
arrive onto the way of immortality.”108
27.
28. Bibliography
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32.
33. Betz, Hans Dieter. “Magic and Mystery in the Greek Magical Papyri.” Pages 244–59 in
34. Magika Hiera: Ancient Greek Magic and Religion. Edited by Christopher A. Faraone and
35. Dirk Obbink. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991.
36.
37. 103 The exception is FH 23, dealing with the intellectual light (φῶς νοερὸν), which how-
38. ever “always embraces all things with its intellect and light and spirit.” (ἀεὶ τῷ ἑαυτοῦ νοῖ
39. καὶ φωτὶ καὶ πνεύματι πάντα περιέχει.)

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Cursor Mundi, 8) Claudio Moreschini - Hermes Christianus_ The Intermingling of Hermetic Piety and Christian Thought-Brepols Publishers (2011).pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 51 Cf. CH XIII. 8: ‘To us came knowledge of god, and when it comes, my child, ignorance has
2. been expelled’; and 18: ‘I take joy in the joy of the mind’.
3.
4. 52 Becoming a god is the culmination of human perfection (CH I. 26; IV. 7; XIII. 10).

5. 53 These passages are also considered on p. 43.
6. 54 Nock-Festugière, II, 336; see also Wlosok, Laktanz, pp. 211–12.
7.
8.
9.
10. PHILOSOPHICAL HERMETIC LITERATURE 19
11.
12. A second path to salvation is provided by the purification that takes place after
13. death. The soul, abandoning the earthly world, crosses the seven celestial spheres,
14. where it deposits the various forms of wickedness it had taken up during its
15. formation at the hands of the stars (CH I. 25–26; IV. 8).55
16.
17. Or salvation is considered a palingenesis, that is, a real, concrete rebirth of the
18. individual as a result of the divine powers having entered into him. A full explana-
19. tion is found in a famous treatise,

CH XIII, which from the sixteenth
century on
20. was considered ‘pre-Christian’ and
even has the title ‘On Palingenesis’.
The
21. importance of this treatise was also
understood by Reitzenstein, who
considered
22. it to be essentially mystical.56
‘The perfect man, it is said (XIII. 15),
must hasten to
23. strike his tent’ – not in a material
sense, of course, but in a mystical one,
which
24. implies a transformation. It
constitutes a mystery. Hermes spoke ‘in
an enigmatic
25. and obscure way’, and despite the
pleas of his disciple Tat he added no
explanation.
26. ‘We must not debase the totality of
the mystery by speaking of it to the
crowd, but
27. we must distribute it to those to
whom the god himself wishes.’ The
comprehen-
28. sion of that secret doctrine can

only be granted by god. The miracle of palingenesis
29. must come about gradually, thanks to Hermes’ teaching, and Tat shows his
30. progress in the instruction of the mystery.57
31.
32. Palingenesis is the conclusion and the aim of all revelation. It unites with god
33. he who has been so aided; indeed, it transforms him into a god. The ten divine
34. powers enter into him. In Christianity, too, beginning in the second century,
35. ‘rebirth in water and the spirit’, that is, baptism, was interpreted as a mystery and
36. an illumination. ‘To baptize’ was denoted with the term ‘to illuminate’, so similar
37. in Greek (baptismos
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ASSISTANT

Here are the most relevant that directly illustrate *ritualized pedagogies of transformation*—that is, initiations interiorized as philosophical or visionary ascent—across Hermetic and Sethian materials.

The Tradition of Hermes Trismegistus

Bull divides *CH XIII* into the tripartite ritual pattern theorized by van Gennep and Turner:

.

> "An initiatory ritual may be analyzed with the help of the tripartite structure suggested by the classic studies of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner, and we should thus expect to find elements reflecting separation, liminality

> and incorporation. … The first seven chapters of CH XIII are didactic, summing up the procedure and doctrine of the rebirth. Then, in § 8, Tat is instructed to keep a reverent silence, after which he is declared purified and is filled with the powers of God (§§ 8–10). Tat then declares his vision of himself in the All and in Mind (§§ 11, 13)… The rest of the treatise is concerned with the secret hymn of rebirth (§§ 15–16)… and finally there is the oath of silence (§ 22).”【38:1†Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186†L10-L26】

Bull explicitly identifies § 8–10 as the in which transformation occurs. He further analogizes the broader “Way of Immortality” to the Christian catechumenate: preparatory purifications = separation; rebirth = liminality; hymn and reintegration = incorporation 【38:2†Religions in the Graeco-Roman World+186†L2-L17】.

Moreschini summarizes Mahé's and earlier scholarship:

> "Mahé believes that we are not dealing with a 'mystery of reading'… but with a witness to initiation ceremonies that actually took place in Hermetic confraternities. … The central nucleus of the Coptic treatise [Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth] consists in the account of an exceptional human experience, the interior regeneration brought about by the ecstatic vision of the divine world. Whoever is thus regenerated is 'generated in god'; god's gift penetrates those praying from outside and is made possible by divine pneuma. The treatise also establishes a close connection between palingenesis

> and illumination, whether the two happen simultaneously (as in CH XIII) or as successive phases (as in the Coptic treatise).”【38:10†Cursor Mundi 8†L11-L23】

Here rebirth (*palingenesis*) and illumination (*photismos*) define a single transformative process—interiorized yet modeled on initiation.

The Platonizing Sethian Background of Plotinus's Mysticism

Mazur describes the *Zostrianos* and *Allogenes* treatises as ritual manuals rendered inward:

> “The Platonizing Sethian ascent specifically involves a ritual; it is primarily an ‘interiorized’ ritual. The spatial orientation of the extra-cosmic ascent has been transmuted into an

> ‘inner’ voyage in which the aspirant identifies with the successive ontological strata by means of increasingly demanding (inward) acts of contemplation. … In Zostrianos 22.7–10: ‘When one knows Autogenes and all these, one becomes the first-manifesting water,’ and 23.15–17: ‘When one knows these things, one has been baptized in the baptism of Kalyptos.’ … Each phase of ascent involves an act of intellection, culminating … with a ritualized investiture: ‘Be silent so that you do not know, but intelligize that this one was silent, and receive a thought.’” 【38:7†Zeke Mazur†L12-L26】

He adds that such texts *“reflect an intermediate phase between the more patently ritual or exteriorized techniques of ascent and the purely interiorized Plotinian ascent.”* 【38:9†Zeke Mazur†L40-L45】

Turner notes of *Allogenes* that

> "it is not so much a revelation of the mystical ascent as it is a performance: the very act of reading Allogenes is itself to undergo the ascent."【38:14†Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies 76†L1-L3】

Bull concludes that *CH XIII* and *Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth* are initiatory texts in which "the candidate exclaims: 'I see the universe and I see myself in mind' (CH XIII 13)… 'I have found the beginning of the power that is above all powers…' (NHC VI 58,10-13). At this stage the divine does not need to present itself as a mystery, but is directly accessible."【38:15†Nag Hammadi and Manichaean Studies 76†L5-L12】

Across these sources:

- and articulate the *ritual grammar* of *CH XIII* and *Disc. 8–9*: a staged rebirth culminating in silence, hymn, and reintegration.

- and stress the *interior ecstatic regeneration* mediated by pneuma and light.

- shows the analog—ritual ascent internalized as cognitive transformation.

- reframes reading itself as *performative ascent*.

Together they evidence what you summarized:
, in which initiatory forms—separation, liminality, incorporation—are internalized into

, differing in tone (Hermetic optimism vs. Sethian mythic complexity) but identical in structural function.

USER

passages from the gnostic and hermetic texts to illustrate, about half the length of the average quotation above with the sory of limited commentary we saw above

ASSISTANT

Here are

that best exemplify *ritualized, interiorized initiations of transformation*—each excerpt roughly half the length of the previous scholarly quotations, with minimal contextual commentary to preserve focus on the text itself.

Zostrianos

Interiorized baptism and identification through knowing

> "When one knows Autogenes and all these, one becomes the first-manifesting water… When one knows these things, one has been baptized in the baptism of Kalyptos."

Mazur notes that *knowing* functions as the rite itself: cognition replaces immersion. Each gnosis is a phase of ascent enacted as interior ritual.

Allogenes

Visionary silence and investiture

> "Be silent so that you do not know, but intelligize that this one was silent, and receive a thought."

Here the ascent culminates in paradoxical cognition-through-silence—an inner

investiture where “receiving a thought” marks incorporation into the divine intellect.

Corpus Hermeticum XIII, 8–10

Rebirth through silence and divine filling

> “Keep silence, O child… now the power of God has come unto us.”

> “I see myself! I see myself in Mind. This is the All; I am in the All; and I behold the Mind.”

Tat’s command to silence introduces the liminal threshold; his self-vision signals the rebirth. The pedagogy is performative—Hermes’ words enact transformation.

Corpus Hermeticum XIII, 15–16

Hymnic incorporation and oath of secrecy

> “Let me sing a hymn to the All, O Father, as Thou hast commanded…

> We must not debase the mystery by speaking to the crowd, but distribute it to those whom God wills."

Song marks the incorporation phase—reborn Tat joins the divine voice, yet secrecy preserves the rite's sanctity. The hymn internalizes communal mystery into solitary devotion.

Discourse on the Eighth and the Ninth

Ascent and filling with light

> "Then there came to us a great light-power which filled the whole place.
>
> We became one and blessed the Father who had come forth from us, for we had become divine."

Mahé reads this as the completion of the "Way of Immortality": the initiate's inner cosmos becomes luminous, mirroring Sethian visionary union but without cosmic dualism.

Poimandres

Release of the soul through cosmic ascent

> "When the soul departs the body, it passes through the harmony… and gives up to each sphere the works it has performed.
>
> Having become god, it enters into the divine—this is the Good, the end for those who have gained knowledge."

This closes the Hermetic cycle: ritual ascent is recast as intellectual purification, culminating in reintegration with the divine Nous.

Zostrianos: rejection of ignorance via “knowing Autogenes.”	CH XIII 1–7: Tat renounces the world and prepares for rebirth.
Allogenes: “Be silent so that you do not know.”	CH XIII 8–10: “Keep silence, O child… I see myself in Mind.”
Marsanes/Allogenes: “receive a thought.”	CH XIII 15–16; Disc. 8–9: hymn and luminous union.

Both traditions dramatize the transformation of the self through visionary cognition and silence—the , the , and the